A blob of annihilation attacks Sharn, the City of Towers, in the world of Eberron.

CHAPTER 3

DM's Toolbox

WHEREAS CHAPTERS 1 AND 2 TEACH THE essentials of being a Dungeon Master, this chapter provides advice on topics that can surface as you prepare or run a D&D game session, as well as rules for adventure elements ranging from chases and doors to traps. It also includes guidance on creating new backgrounds, creatures, magic items, and spells to amuse your players.

Alignment

As described in the *Player's Handbook*, alignment is a roleplaying tool. It is a quick way to describe a creature's moral and ethical orientation. Like other elements of the game, it's meant to be a tool to serve you and your game, not a constraint or burden. Alignment can help your game in three ways: as a tool for player characters, as a descriptor of a creature's demeanor, and as a summary of an organization's ethos.

Character Alignment

Some common misconceptions about alignment can cause conflicts between players and DMs. The following sections can help you navigate how player characters interact with alignment.

Actions Indicate Alignment

A character might think they're good and profess to believe that senseless slaughter is wrong, but if that character repeatedly engages in senseless slaughter, the character's beliefs aren't what they profess.

Alignment doesn't limit the actions characters can take; rather, the actions they take indicate what their alignment is. It's OK to stray from the tenets of one's alignment now and then, and players can (and should) change their characters' alignments if these alignments no longer describe their characters.

Good and Evil Can Cooperate

Good and evil characters can share common goals, though they'll likely use different tactics to pursue those goals.

Imagine two characters—one Lawful Good, the other Lawful Evil—who are both dedicated to stopping monsters from preying on the people of their city. The Lawful Evil character is willing to employ methods (such as bribing or threatening potential witnesses) that the Lawful Good character isn't.

When good- and evil-aligned adventurers coexist in the same party, they're likely to have disagreements as the campaign unfolds. Many players enjoy roleplaying such conflicts, but see "Ensuring Fun for All" in chapter 1 if you run into trouble with evil characters played in a disruptive way.

Planes and Alignment

The Outer Planes (described in chapter 6) are realms where alignment manifests in reality. When creatures explore the Outer Planes, they can experience those realms differently depending on their alignment.

Monster Alignment

Alignment can help you determine how a creature behaves in your game in two simple ways.

Starting Attitude

A creature's alignment can help you determine the creature's attitude in an encounter. A Chaotic Evil monster is likely to be Hostile, while a Lawful Good one is more likely to have a Friendly attitude, ready to help those in need.

Personality

Chapter 2 of the *Player's Handbook* offers a table of brief personality traits linked to alignment that can inspire you in playing an NPC or another monster in your game.

Organization Ethos

It can be useful to assign an alignment to an organization—including a faction, a guild, or a nation—to describe its ethos. This can help you decide how groups interact with each other.

An organization's ethos doesn't dictate the alignment of its members or even the alignment of its leaders. In fact, a stark difference between a society's ethos and the alignment of its leadership can generate interesting material for adventure. For example, imagine a Neutral Good queen ascending to the throne of a Lawful Evil empire and struggling to reform its institutions.



An exciting chase nears its conclusion.

Chases

The rules for movement in combat don't translate to every situation. In particular, they can make a potentially thrilling chase seem dull and predictable. Faster creatures always catch up to slower ones, while creatures with the same Speed never close the distance between each other. Use the following rules to introduce random elements that make chases more exciting.

Know the capabilities of the characters in your party before you make a chase an important feature of an adventure. A character with a high Speed or the right spell (such as *Dimension Door*, *Fly*, or *Hold Monster*) can often end a chase before it begins.

Beginning a Chase

A chase requires at least one quarry and at least one pursuer. Any participants not already in Initiative order must roll Initiative as the chase begins. As in combat, each participant in the chase can take one action and move on its turn.

When a chase begins, determine the starting distance between the quarry and the pursuers. Track the distance between them, and designate the pursuer closest to the quarry as the lead. The lead pursuer might change from round to round.

Running the Chase

Participants in the chase are strongly motivated to take the Dash action every round. Pursuers who stop to cast spells and make attacks run the risk of losing their quarry, and a quarry that doesn't take the Dash action is likely to be caught.

Dashing

A chase participant can take the Dash action a number of times equal to 3 plus its Constitution modifier (minimum of once). Each additional Dash action it takes during the chase requires the creature to succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw at the end of its turn or gain 1 Exhaustion level. A participant drops out of the chase if its Speed is 0.

Spells and Attacks

A chase participant can make attacks and cast spells against other creatures within range.

Chase participants can't normally make Opportunity Attacks against each other, since they are all assumed to be moving in the same direction at the same time. However, participants can still be the targets of Opportunity Attacks from creatures not participating in the chase. For example, adventurers who chase a thief past a gang of ruffians might provoke Opportunity Attacks from the ruffians.

Ending a Chase

A chase ends when one side or the other stops, when each quarry escapes, or when the pursuers are close enough to their quarry to catch it.

If neither side gives up the chase, the quarry makes a Dexterity (Stealth) check on Initiative count 0 each round, after every participant in the chase has taken its turn. If the quarry is never out of the lead pursuer's sight, the check fails automatically. Otherwise, compare the check's total to the Passive Perception scores of the pursuers. If the quarry consists of multiple creatures, they all make the check separately, so it's possible for one quarry to escape while others remain in the chase.

The quarry can gain Advantage or Disadvantage on its check based on the circumstances, as shown in the Escape Factors table.

Escape Factors

Factor	Check Has ...
Many things to hide behind	Advantage
A very crowded area	Advantage
Few things to hide behind	Disadvantage
An uncrowded area	Disadvantage

Other factors might help or hinder the quarry's ability to escape, at your discretion. For example, a quarry with a *Faerie Fire* spell cast on it might have Disadvantage on checks made to escape because it's much easier to spot.

If the total of the quarry's check is greater than the highest Passive Perception score of the pursuers, the quarry escapes. If not, the chase continues for another round. Escape doesn't necessarily mean the quarry has outpaced its pursuers. For example, in a city, escape might mean the quarry ducked into a crowd or slipped around a corner, leaving no clue as to where it went.

Splitting Up

Creatures being chased can split up into smaller groups. This tactic forces pursuers to either divide their forces or allow some of the quarry to escape. If a pursuit splits into several smaller chases, resolve each chase separately. You can keep all the creatures in Initiative order, but track the distances separately for each group.

Role Reversal

During a chase, it's possible for the pursuers to become the quarry. For example, characters chasing a thief through a marketplace might draw unwanted attention from other members of the thieves' guild. As they pursue the fleeing thief, they must also evade the thieves pursuing them. Roll Initiative for the new arrivals, and run both chases simultaneously. Alternatively, the fleeing thief might run into his accomplices. The outnumbered characters might then flee with the thieves in pursuit.

Mapping the Chase

When you plan a chase, draw a rough map that shows the route. Insert obstacles and complications at specific points, especially ones that require the characters to make ability checks or saving throws to avoid slowing or stopping, or use the random tables of complications in the "Chase Complications" section to choose obstacles that occur at specific points.

Complications can be barriers to progress or opportunities for mayhem. Characters being chased through a forest by bugbears might spot a wasp nest and slow down long enough to attack the nest or throw rocks at it to enrage the wasps within, thus creating an obstacle for their pursuers.

A map of a chase can be linear or have many branches, depending on the nature of the chase. For example, a mine cart chase might have few (if any) branches, while a sewer chase might have several.

Chase Complications

Unexpected complications make a chase more exciting. The accompanying Urban Chase Complications table and Wilderness Chase Complications table provide several examples. Each participant in the chase rolls 1d12 at the end of its turn. Consult the appropriate table to determine whether a complication occurs. If it does, it affects the next chase participant in the Initiative order, not the participant who rolled the die.

Characters can create their own complications to shake off pursuers or slow their quarry (for example, casting the *Web* spell in a narrow alleyway). Adjudicate these at your discretion.

Designing Your Own Chase Tables

Unusual environments might suggest unique chase tables. A chase through the sewers of the Free City of Greyhawk or through the spiderweb-filled alleys of Menzoberranzan (a subterranean city teeming with spiders and worshipers of Lolth) might inspire you to create your own tables.

Urban Chase Complications

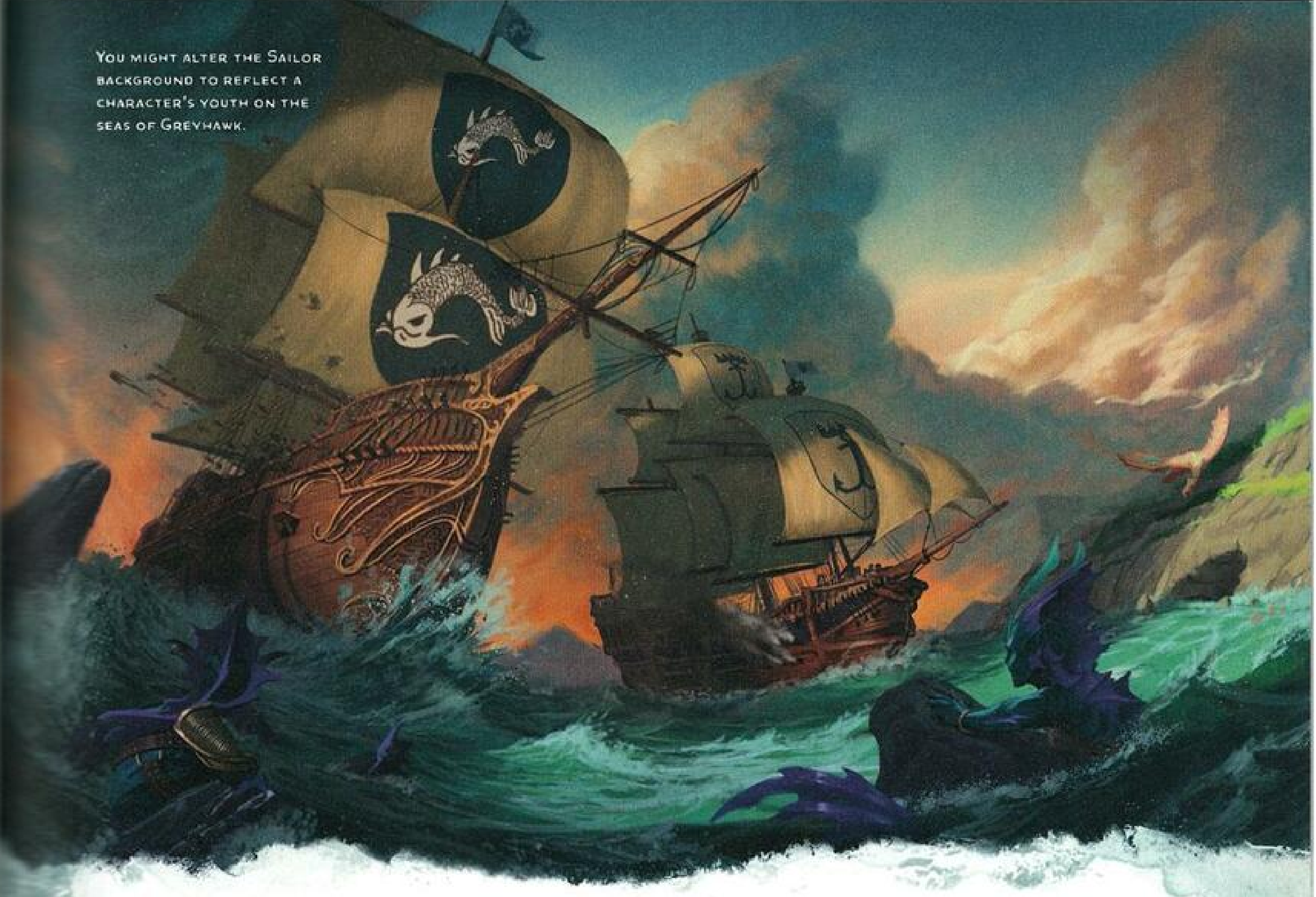
1d12	Complication
1	A cart or another large obstacle blocks your way. Make a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw to get past the obstacle. On a failed save, the obstacle counts as 10 feet of Difficult Terrain for you.
2	A crowd blocks your way. Make a DC 10 Strength, Dexterity, or Charisma saving throw (your choice) to navigate through the crowd. On a failed save, the crowd counts as 10 feet of Difficult Terrain for you.
3	A maze of barrels, crates, or similar obstacles stands in your way. Make a DC 10 Dexterity or Intelligence saving throw (your choice) to navigate the maze. On a failed save, the maze counts as 10 feet of Difficult Terrain for you.
4	The ground is slippery with rain, spilled oil, or some other liquid. Make a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw. On a failed save, you have the Prone condition.
5	You encounter a brawl in progress. Make a DC 15 Strength, Dexterity, or Charisma saving throw (your choice) to get past the brawlers unimpeded. On a failed save, you take 2d4 Bludgeoning damage, and the brawlers count as 10 feet of Difficult Terrain for you.
6	You must make a sharp turn to avoid colliding with something impassable. Make a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw to navigate the turn. On a failed save, you collide with something hard and take 1d4 Bludgeoning damage.
7–12	There is no complication.

Wilderness Chase Complications

1d12	Complication
1	You pass through a **Swarm of Insects** (see the *Monster Manual*, with the DM choosing whichever kind of insects makes the most sense). The swarm uses one of its actions, targeting you.
2	A stream or ravine blocks your path. Make a DC 10 Strength or Dexterity saving throw (your choice) to cross the impediment. On a failed save, the impediment counts as 10 feet of Difficult Terrain for you.
3	Make a DC 10 Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, blowing sand, dirt, ash, snow, or pollen causes you to have the Blinded condition until the end of your turn. While you are Blinded in this way, your Speed is halved.
4	A sudden drop catches you by surprise. Make a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw to navigate the impediment. On a failed save, you fall 10 feet.
5	Your path takes you near a patch of razorvine (see "Hazards" in this chapter). Make a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or use 10 feet of movement (your choice) to avoid the razorvine. On a failed save, you take 1d10 Slashing damage.
6	A creature native to the area notices you. (The DM chooses a creature appropriate for the terrain.) Make a DC 10 Wisdom or Charisma saving throw (your choice). On a failed save, the creature joins the chase, with you as its quarry.
7–12	There is no complication.



An ill-advised attempt to steal Xanathar's pet goldfish, Sylgar, leads to a heated chase.



Creating a Background

A character's background represents what the character did prior to becoming an adventurer. Creating a unique background or customizing an existing one from the *Player's Handbook* can reflect the particular theme of your campaign or elements of your world. You can also create a background to help a player craft the story they have in mind for their character.

This section describes, step by step, how you can create backgrounds like the ones in the *Player's Handbook*, tailored for your world and the heroes in it.

1: Choose Abilities

Choose three abilities that seem appropriate for the background:

Strength or Dexterity. These abilities are ideal for a background involving physical exertion.

Constitution. This ability is ideal for a background that involves endurance or long hours of activity.

Intelligence or Wisdom. One or both abilities are ideal for a background that focuses on cerebral or spiritual matters.

Charisma. This ability is ideal for a background that involves performance or social interaction.

2: Choose a Feat

Choose one feat from the Origin category. See the *Player's Handbook* for examples of Origin feats.

3: Choose Skill Proficiencies

Choose two skills appropriate for the background. There needn't be a relationship between the skill proficiencies a background grants and the ability scores it increases.

4: Choose a Tool Proficiency

Choose one tool used in the practice of the background or often associated with it.

5: Choose Equipment

Assemble a package of equipment worth 50 GP (including unspent gold). Don't include Martial weapons or armor, as characters get them from their class choices.



Creating a Creature

Use the approaches and examples in the following sections to build custom creatures for your game.

Minor Alterations

You can change the superficial details of a creature's appearance however you like, and you can alter any of the following pieces of a monster's stat block without impacting its functionality.

Size and Creature Type

You can alter a creature's size and creature type as you please. For example, you can use an **Ogre** stat block for a human bully—just make it a Medium Humanoid instead of a Large Giant.

Ability Scores

You can usually change a creature's Intelligence, Wisdom, and Charisma scores freely unless the ability is used for spellcasting. For example, a **Black Pudding** stat block could represent a sapient alien if you raise its Intelligence and Charisma to 10 or so. It's usually best to leave its Strength, Dexterity, and Constitution scores alone, as changes to these scores can alter a monster's attack bonus, damage, Armor Class, or Hit Points, which in turn can alter its Challenge Rating.

Languages

You can change any or all of the languages the creature knows. You might want to add languages if you've made a creature sapient that wasn't before. You can also add or remove telepathy or other forms of communication.

Proficiencies

You can give a creature any skill proficiencies you want and give it Expertise if you want it to be very skilled. If you want a creature to be good at hiding, give it Expertise in the Stealth skill. If its keen senses make it an excellent tracker or otherwise adept at finding hidden foes, give it Expertise in the Perception skill. (You can also increase its Wisdom, as noted above.)

You can also swap a monster's saving throw proficiencies. If it has none, you can add one or two.

Senses

Blindsight, Darkvision, Tremorsense, and Truesight have no bearing on a creature's Challenge Rating. You can add or remove them freely.

Spells

If a stat block has spells, you can replace any of its spells with a different spell of the same level. Avoid replacing a spell that deals damage with one that doesn't and vice versa.

Attacks

You can freely change the name and flavor of an attack, as well as its damage type. For example, you can turn an ordinary **Skeleton** into an ice skeleton that deals Cold damage as it accosts characters with a blade of ice or hurls shards of ice at them.

Resistances and Immunities

If a creature doesn't have Resistance or Immunity to one or more damage types, you can give it Resistance or Immunity to one or two damage types. You can also change the damage type of its existing Resistances and Immunities.

Traits

You can add traits to a creature's stat block to communicate aspects of the creature's nature. See the Creature Traits list for sample traits.

You can also use traits from other stat blocks in the *Monster Manual*, provided you don't add traits that alter a creature's Hit Points, confer Temporary Hit Points, or change the amount of damage the creature deals to other creatures.

Creature Traits

Aversion to Fire. If the creature takes Fire damage, it has Disadvantage on attack rolls and ability checks until the end of its next turn.

Battle Ready. The creature has Advantage on Initiative rolls.

Beast Whisperer. The creature can communicate with Beasts as if they shared a common language.

Death Jinx. When the creature dies, one random creature within 10 feet of the dead creature is targeted by a *Bane* spell (save DC 13), which lasts for its full duration.

Dimensional Disruption. Disruptive energy extends from the creature in a 30-foot Emanation. Other creatures can't teleport to or from a space in that area. Any attempt to do so is wasted.

Disciple of the Nine Hells. When the creature dies, its body disgorges a Hostile **Imp** in the same space.

Disintegration. When the creature dies, its body and nonmagical possessions turn to dust. Any magic items it possessed are left behind in its space.

Emissary of Juiblex. When the creature dies, its body disgorges a Hostile **Ochre Jelly** in the same space.

Fey Ancestry. The creature has Advantage on saving throws it makes to avoid or end the Charmed condition, and magic can't put it to sleep.

Forbiddance. The creature can't enter a residence without an invitation from one of its occupants.

Gloom Shroud. Imperceptible energy channeled from the Shadowfell extends from the creature in a 20-foot Emanation. Other creatures in that area have Disadvantage on Charisma checks and Charisma saving throws.

Light. The creature sheds Bright Light in a 10-foot radius and Dim Light for an additional 10 feet. As a Bonus Action, the creature can suppress this light or cause it to return. The light winks out if the creature dies.

Mimicry. The creature can mimic Beast sounds and Humanoid voices. A creature that hears the sounds can tell they are imitations with a successful DC 14 Wisdom (Insight) check.

Poison Tolerant. The creature has Advantage on saving throws it makes to avoid or end the Poisoned condition.

Resonant Connection. The creature has a supernatural connection to another creature or an object and knows the most direct route to it, provided the two are within 1 mile of each other.

Siege Monster. The creature deals double damage to objects and structures.

Slaad Host. When the creature dies, a Hostile **Slaad Tadpole** bursts from its innards in the same space.

Steadfast. The creature has Immunity to the Frightened condition while it can see an ally within 30 feet of itself.

Telepathic Bond. The creature is linked psychically to another creature. While both are on the same plane of existence, they can communicate telepathically with each other.

Telepathic Shroud. The creature is immune to any effect that would sense its emotions or read its thoughts, as well as to spells from the school of Divination. As a Bonus Action, the creature can suppress this trait or reactivate it.

Ventriloquism. Whenever the creature speaks, it can choose a point within 30 feet of itself; its voice emanates from that point.

Warrior's Wrath. The creature has Advantage on melee attack rolls against any Bloodied creature.

Wild Talent. Choose one cantrip; the creature can cast that cantrip without spell components, using Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma as the spellcasting ability.

Creating a Magic Item

The magic items in chapter 7 are but a few of the magic treasures that characters can discover during their adventures. You can modify these magic items or create new ones using the guidelines in this section.

Rules for characters crafting magic items are in chapter 7.

Modifying a Magic Item

You can create a new magic item by tweaking one or more existing ones. Suggestions are provided in the sections that follow.

Altered Capabilities

One capability can replace a similar one. For example, a *Potion of Climbing* could become a *Potion of Swimming*.

Altered Form

You can alter a magic item's form while leaving its properties intact. For example, you can turn a *Ring of the Ram* into a wand or a *Cloak of Protection* into some other worn object (such as a circlet) without altering the item's properties.

Altered Damage Types

An item that deals damage of one type could instead deal damage of another type. For example, a *Flame Tongue* sword could deal Lightning damage instead of Fire damage.

Combining Items

You can merge the properties of two magic items of the same rarity into a single item, provided no more than one of them requires Attunement. For example, you could combine the properties of a *Helm of Comprehending Languages* with those of a *Helm of Telepathy* into a single helmet. This makes the item more powerful (and probably increases its rarity), but it won't break your game.

Special Features and Sentience

Chapter 7 has rules for giving magic items interesting histories, minor properties, quirks, and sentience.

Creating a New Item

If modifying an item doesn't quite fulfill the need, you can create one from scratch.

A magic item should either let a character do something they couldn't do before or improve the character's ability to do something they can do already. For example, a *Ring of Jumping* lets its wearer jump greater distances, thus augmenting what a character can already do. A *Ring of the Ram*, however, gives a character the ability to deal Force damage.

The simpler your approach, the easier it is for a character to use the item in play. Giving the item charges is fine, especially if it has several different abilities, but simply deciding that an item is always active or can be used a fixed number of times per day might be easier to manage.

Power Level

If you make an item that lets a character kill whatever they hit with it, that item will likely unbalance your game. On the other hand, an item whose benefit rarely comes into play isn't much of a reward.

Use the Magic Item Power by Rarity table as a guide to help you determine how powerful a magic item should be based on its rarity.

Magic Item Power by Rarity

Rarity	Max. Spell Level	Max. Bonus
Common	1	—
Uncommon	3	+1
Rare	5	+2
Very Rare	8	+3
Legendary	9	+4

Maximum Spell Level. This column of the table indicates the highest-level spell effect the item should confer, in the form of a once-per-day or similarly limited property. For example, a Common magic item might confer the benefit of a level 1 spell once per day (or just once if it's consumable). A Rare, Very Rare, or Legendary magic item might allow its possessor to cast a lower-level spell more frequently.

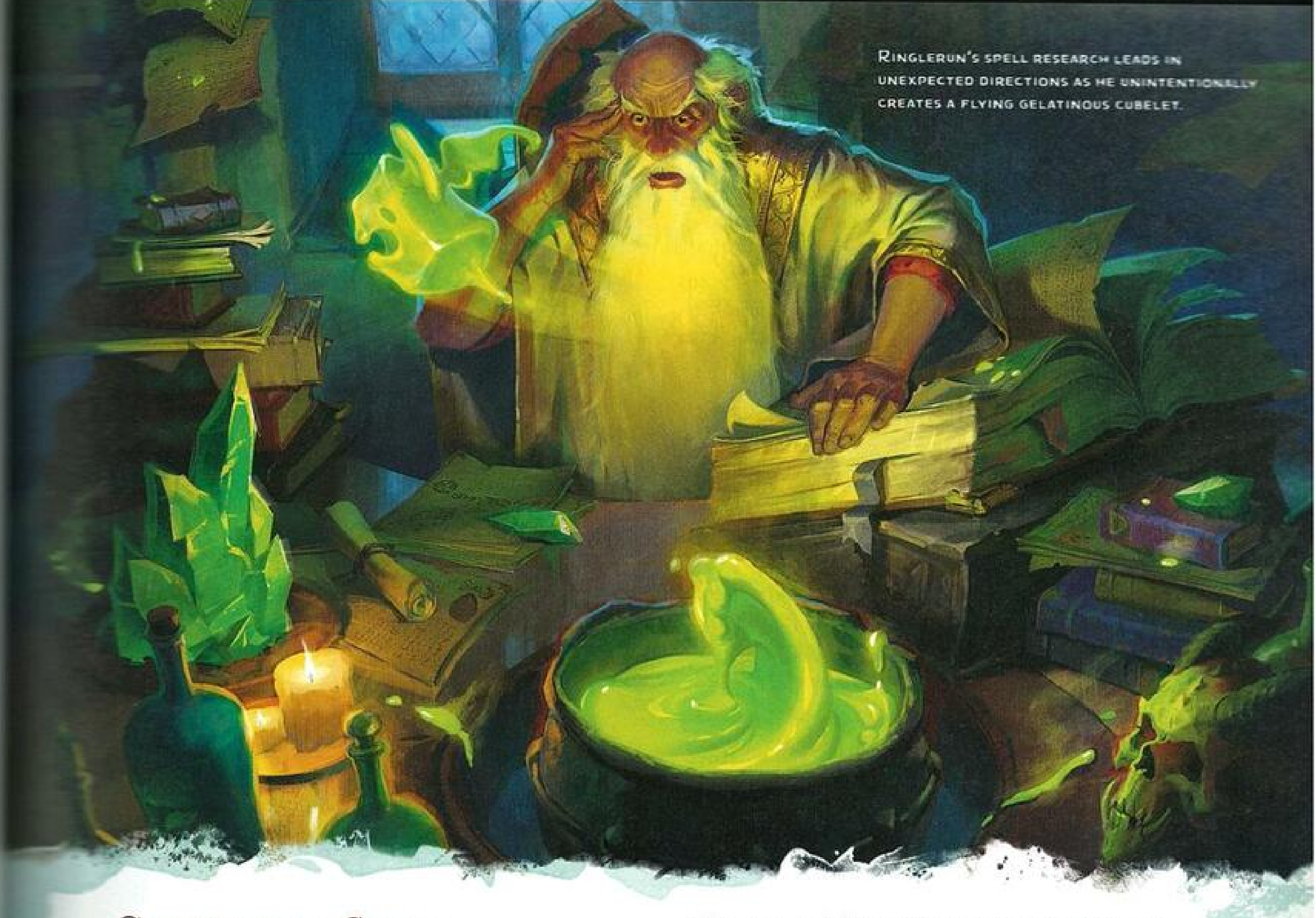
Maximum Bonus. If an item delivers a static bonus to AC, attack rolls, saving throws, or ability checks, this column suggests an appropriate bonus based on the item's rarity.

Attunement

Decide whether the item requires a character to be attuned to it to use its properties. Consider the following guidelines.

Limit Sharing. If having all the characters in a party pass an item around to gain its lasting benefits would be disruptive, the item should require Attunement.

Limit Stacking. If the item grants a bonus that other items also grant, it's a good idea to require Attunement so characters don't try to collect too many of those items.



Ringlerun's spell research leads in unexpected directions as he unintentionally creates a flying gelatinous cubelet.

Creating a Spell

When creating a new spell, use existing ones as examples. Here are some things to consider:

Name. The spell must have a unique name.

Balance. If the spell is so good that a caster would want to use it all the time, it's probably too powerful for its level.

Identity. Make sure the spell fits with the identity of those who can cast it. Sorcerers and Wizards don't typically cast healing spells, for example.

Spell Duration, Range, and Area. A longer duration, greater range, or larger area can make up for a lesser effect, depending on the spell.

Utility. Avoid spells that have very limited use, such as one that works only against Oozes. Few characters will bother to learn or prepare such a spell.

Spell Damage

For any spell that deals damage, use the Spell Damage table to determine approximately how much damage is appropriate given the spell's level. The table assumes the spell deals half as much damage on a successful saving throw or a missed attack. If your spell doesn't deal damage on a successful save, you can increase the damage by 25 percent.

You can use different damage dice than the ones in the table if the average damage is about the same. For example, you could change a cantrip's damage from 1d10 (average 5.5) to 2d4 (average 5), reducing the maximum damage and making an average result more likely.

Spell Damage

Spell Level	One Target	Multiple Targets
Cantrip	1d10	1d6
1	2d10	2d6
2	3d10	3d6
3	5d10	6d6
4	6d10	7d6
5	7d10	8d6
6	10d10	11d6
7	11d10	12d6
8	12d10	13d6
9	15d10	16d6

Healing Spells

You can also use the Spell Damage table to determine how many Hit Points a healing spell restores. A cantrip shouldn't provide healing.

Curses and Magical Contagions

A curse is a magical burden that lasts for a specified time or until it is ended by some means. A magical contagion is an adverse effect of magical origin that is contagious by definition.

The following sections discuss curses and magical contagions in detail.

Curses

A curse typically takes one of the forms detailed below.

Bestow Curse

The simplest curses are created by the *Bestow Curse* spell. The effects of such curses are limited and can be ended by the *Remove Curse* spell.

Bestow Curse provides useful benchmarks for gauging the potency of other curses. A curse that lasts for 1 minute equates to a level 3 spell, while one that lasts until dispelled equates to a level 9 spell.

Cursed Creatures

Some monsters are associated with curses, whether as part of their origins or due to their ability to spread curses—werewolves being a prime example.

You decide how a spell like *Remove Curse* affects a creature with accursed origins. For example, you might decide that a mummy was created through a curse and it can be destroyed permanently only by casting *Remove Curse* on its corpse.

Cursed Magic Items

Cursed magic items are created deliberately or originate as the result of supernatural events. Such items are detailed in chapter 7.

Narrative Curses

A curse might manifest during an adventure when a creature's violation of a taboo warrants supernatural punishment, such as breaking a vow, defiling a tomb, or murdering an innocent. Such a curse can have any effects you design, or it might be a customized version of another type of curse discussed in this section.

A creature affected by such a curse should know why they're being punished and be able to learn how to end their curse, likely by symbolically righting the wrong they committed. How a spell like *Remove Curse* affects a curse that's part of your adventure is up to you—the spell might merely suppress the effects of the curse for a time. Regardless, narrative curses should feel like rare, potent magic rooted in the lore of your campaign.



The curse of Demonic Possession has devastating effects.

Environmental Curses

Some locations are so suffused with evil that anyone who lingers there is burdened with a curse. Demonic Possession is one example of an environmental curse.

Demonic Possession. Demonic Possession arises from the chaos and evil of the Abyss and commonly besets creatures that interact with demonic objects or linger in desecrated locations, where demonic spirits await victims.

A creature that becomes the target of Demonic Possession must succeed on a DC 15 Charisma saving throw or be possessed by a bodiless demonic entity. Whenever the possessed creature rolls a 1 on a D20 Test, the demonic entity takes control of the creature and determines the creature's behavior thereafter. At the end of each of the possessed creature's later turns, the creature makes a DC 15 Charisma saving throw, regaining control of itself on a success.

After finishing a Long Rest, a creature with Demonic Possession makes a DC 15 Charisma saving throw. On a successful save, the effect ends on the creature. A *Dispel Evil and Good* spell or any magic that removes a curse also ends the effect on it.

Magical Contagions

Alchemists, potion brewers, and areas of wild magic are credited with creating the first magical contagions. An outbreak of such a contagion can form the basis of an adventure as characters search for a cure and try to stop the contagion's spread.

Rest and Recuperation

If a creature infected with a magical contagion spends 3 days recuperating—engaging in no activities that would interrupt a Long Rest—the creature makes a DC 15 Constitution saving throw at the end of the recuperation period. On a successful save, the creature has Advantage on saving throws to fight off the magical contagion for the next 24 hours.

Example Contagions

The following examples show how magical contagions can work. Feel free to alter the saving throw DCs, effects, and other characteristics of these contagions to suit your campaign.

Cackle Fever

Magical Contagion

Cheaply made potions and elixirs are sometimes tainted by Cackle Fever, which affects Humanoids only (gnomes are strangely immune). A creature suffers the following effects 1d4 days after infection:

Fever. The creature gains 1 Exhaustion level, which lasts until the contagion ends on the creature.

Uncontrollable Laughter. While the creature has the Exhaustion condition, the creature makes a DC 13 Constitution saving throw each time it takes damage other than Psychic damage. On a failed save, the creature takes 5 (1d10) Psychic damage and has the Incapacitated condition as it laughs uncontrollably. At the end of each of its turns, the creature repeats the save, ending the effect on itself on a success. After 1 minute, it succeeds automatically.

Fighting the Contagion. At the end of each Long Rest, an infected creature makes a DC 13 Constitution saving throw. After the creature succeeds on three of these saves, the contagion ends on it, and the creature is immune to Cackle Fever for 1 year.

Spreading the Contagion. Any Humanoid (other than a gnome) that starts its turn within a 10-foot Emanation originating from a creature infected with Cackle Fever must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw or also become infected with the contagion. On a successful save, the Humanoid can't catch the contagion from that particular infected creature for the next 24 hours.

Sewer Plague

Magical Contagion

Fouled potions and alchemical waste can give rise to Sewer Plague, which incubates in sewers and refuse heaps and is sometimes transmitted by creatures that dwell in such areas, including otyughs and rats. Any Humanoid that is wounded by a creature that carries the contagion or that comes into contact with contaminated filth or offal must succeed on a DC 11 Constitution saving throw or become infected with Sewer Plague. A creature suffers the following effects 1d4 days after infection:

Fatigue. The creature gains 1 Exhaustion level.

Weakness. While the creature has any Exhaustion levels, it regains only half the normal number of Hit Points from spending Hit Point Dice.

Restlessness. While the creature has any Exhaustion levels, finishing a Long Rest neither restores lost Hit Points nor reduces the creature's Exhaustion level.

Fighting the Contagion. Daily at dawn, an infected creature makes a DC 11 Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the creature gains 1 Exhaustion level as its fatigue worsens. On a successful save, the creature's Exhaustion level decreases by 1. If the creature's Exhaustion level is reduced to 0, the contagion ends on the creature.

Sight Rot

Magical Contagion

Any Beast or Humanoid that drinks water tainted by Sight Rot must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or have the Blinded condition until the contagion ends.

Fighting the Contagion. Magic such as a *Heal* or *Lesser Restoration* spell ends the contagion immediately. A character who is proficient with an Herbalism Kit can use it to create one dose of nonmagical ointment, which takes 1 hour. When applied to the eyes of a creature suffering from Sight Rot, the ointment suppresses the contagion on that creature for 24 hours. If the contagion is suppressed in this way for a total of 72 hours (requiring three doses and applications of the ointment), the contagion ends on the creature.

Spreading the Contagion. Any Humanoid that makes skin contact with a creature infected with Sight Rot must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or also become infected with the contagion. On a successful save, the Humanoid can't catch the contagion from that particular infected creature for the next 24 hours.

Death

Adventures involve risk, with consequences that can be as catastrophic as the death of a single character or an entire group. Given the degree to which players get attached to their characters, character death can be an emotionally charged situation. It might even be a hard limit for some players (see "Ensuring Fun for All" in chapter 1), so it's worth having a conversation about how to handle character death at the start of a new game.

Death Must Be Fair

The best way to avoid hard feelings connected to the death of a beloved character is to make sure the players know you're being fair. Keep these principles in mind:

Don't Cheat in the Monsters' Favor. Rolling dice in front of the players when a situation is especially deadly is one way to communicate that you're not cheating in the monsters' favor or singling out a single character for punishment.

Don't Make It Personal. Don't punish a character for a player's behavior or some personal grudge. That's probably the quickest way to undermine your players' trust in you as DM and as a fair arbiter of the rules.

Provide Fair Warning. Let characters face the consequences of their foolish actions, but make sure you give enough cues for the players to recognize self-destructive actions. You might want to ask a player, "Are you sure?" before committing a character to a potentially fatal course of action.

Fair Encounters. Your players have to know that you're fair in designing encounters. It's fine to throw tough encounters at them and sometimes to let them face monsters they can't beat. But it's not fair if the players have no way to know they can't win the fight or have no way to escape.

Scaling Lethality

You can adjust the lethality of your campaign using the encounter-building guidelines in chapter 4. If your players enjoy games that test their characters to the utmost and are prepared to create new characters at a moment's notice, consider using high-difficulty encounters over and over, with little opportunity for rests between encounters, to create a more lethal adventure. Conversely, using only low-difficulty encounters is less likely to lead to character death, especially if characters have ample opportunity to rest during the adventure.



Defeated, Not Dead

If you and your players agree to avoid character death in your game, you might consider an alternative: a character who would otherwise die is instead "defeated." The following rules apply to a defeated character.

Comatose. The character has 1 Hit Point and the Unconscious condition. The character can regain Hit Points as normal, but the character remains Unconscious until they are targeted by a *Greater Restoration* spell or experience a sudden awakening (see below).

Sudden Awakening. After finishing a Long Rest, the character makes a DC 20 Constitution saving throw. On a successful save, the Unconscious condition ends on the character. On a failed save, the condition persists.

Death Scenes

When a character is reduced to 0 Hit Points, the player sometimes has to sit out one or more rounds of combat with nothing to do but roll Death Saving Throws. One way to keep a player involved in the game is to prompt some roleplaying along with each Death Save. You might ask the player to describe a memory that surfaces in the character's mind while hovering near death. Consider these possibilities:

On a Successful Death Save. A memory that inspires hope and courage. A beloved person who would urge the character to cling to life. A thought of something to live for. A favorite childhood memory.

On a Failed Death Save. A memory that stirs up shame or grief. A beloved person who is already dead, beckoning the character to join them. An experience of weariness or despair.

You can also reward a player who describes a memory or something else occupying the dying character's thoughts with Advantage on the Death Save.

When a character dies, either from failed Death Saves or from an effect that kills the character outright, consider giving the player some ownership over the character's final moments by asking what the character's last words are or how the character greets death.

Dealing with Death

When a character dies, consult with the players to decide what happens next. Some players are perfectly happy to make new characters, especially when they're eager to try out new options. A new party member should start at the same level as the other characters in the party and have gear of similar value.

It's also possible for dead characters to be brought back to life. The most common way is through spells such as *Revivify* and *Raise Dead*. It's up to you to decide how easy it is for characters to access those spells if they can't cast them. The *Player's Handbook* offers suggested prices for spellcasting services.

What If Everyone Dies?

Misadventure can wipe out an entire group. (You'll sometimes hear players refer to this as a "total party kill" or "TPK.") Such a catastrophe doesn't have to end the whole game—rather, it presents an opportunity to take the game in a new direction. Consider these possibilities.

A Fresh Start

Everyone makes new characters, and the campaign starts anew. This might be the most drastic option, but it allows for new stories and fresh character dynamics.

Divine Council

The characters find themselves before a council of deities who are arguing about the characters' fate. The characters must convince the council to return them to life.

Escape from the Underworld

The dead characters wake up in Hades (see chapter 6) and must find a way to escape the grim underworld and return to the world of the living.

Imprisoned

The characters wake up in cells, kept alive and imprisoned by their foes for some purpose.

Raised by Another

A powerful individual finds the adventurers' bodies and has them raised from the dead, putting the adventurers in the debt of their rescuer. What if the adventurers wake up decades after their death, returned to life by a *Resurrection* spell cast by someone who believed they had an important role to play in this future era?

Rescue Mission

The players create new, temporary characters who are tasked with retrieving the bodies of the fallen heroes, so they can be raised from the dead or given proper burials. If the dead characters have Bastions (see chapter 8), the stand-in party could consist of hirelings from those Bastions.

Doors

Adventurers interact with doors often in a D&D campaign. This section gives rules for most of the doors the adventurers encounter.

Common Doors

The Doors table provides the AC and Hit Points for common doors, which are Medium objects.

With the Utilize action, a creature can try to force open a door that is barred or locked, doing so with a successful Strength (Athletics) check. The table provides the DC of the check. For bigger doors, double or triple the Hit Points and increase the DC of the check by 5.

Doors

Door	AC	HP	DC to Open
Glass door	13	4	10
Metal door	19	72	25
Stone door	17	40	20
Wooden door	15	18	15

Barred Door

A barred door has no lock. A creature on the barred side of the door can take the Utilize action to lift the bar from its braces, allowing the door to be opened.

Locked Door

Characters who don't have the key to a locked door can try to pick the lock using Thieves' Tools. The Lock Complexity table tells you how long it takes to try to pick a lock based on its complexity. At the end of that time, the character picks the lock by making a successful Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check using Thieves' Tools. The DC is determined by the lock's quality, as shown in the Lock Quality table.

Lock Complexity

Complexity	Time
Simple	1 action
Complex	1 minute

Lock Quality

Quality	DC to Unlock
Inferior	10
Good	15
Superior	20

Secret Doors

A secret door is crafted to blend into the wall that surrounds it. Sometimes faint cracks in the wall or scuff marks on the floor betray the secret door's presence. Other than the fact that it's hidden, a secret door is similar to a common door.

With the Search action, a character can search for a secret door along a 10-foot-square section of wall and make a Wisdom (Perception) check. On a successful check, the character finds any secret door hidden in that section of wall as well as the mechanism to open the door. The DC of the check depends on how well the secret door is hidden, as shown in the Secret Doors table.

You can instead call for an Intelligence (Investigation) check if the challenge involves deducing that a door is present from noticeable clues, rather than spotting those clues in the first place. See "Perception" in chapter 2 for more advice.

Secret Doors

Secret Door	DC to Detect
Barely hidden secret door	10
Standard secret door	15
Well-hidden secret door	20

Secret Door Etiquette

Adventurers often fail to locate secret doors. For this reason, don't hide important treasures or locations behind secret doors unless you're comfortable with the characters not finding them, and don't risk letting your adventure grind to a halt because the only path forward is hidden behind a secret door.

Portcullises

Typically made of iron or wood, a portcullis blocks a passage or an archway until it is raised into the ceiling by a winch and chain. Creatures within 5 feet of a lowered portcullis can make ranged attacks or cast spells through it, and they have Three-Quarters Cover against attacks, spells, and other effects originating from the opposite side. A portcullis can also be attacked and destroyed, using the AC and Hit Points of a metal door (if iron) or a wooden door (if wood).

Winching a portcullis up or down requires the Utilize action. If a creature can't reach the winch (usually because it's on the other side of the portcullis), lifting the portcullis requires the Utilize action and a successful Strength (Athletics) check. The DC of the check depends on the type of portcullis, as shown in the Portcullises table.

Portcullises

Portcullis Size	Iron DC	Wood DC
Medium (8 ft. tall × 5 ft. wide)	20	15
Large (10 ft. tall × 10 ft. wide)	25	20
Huge (20 ft. tall × 15 ft. wide)	30	25

Dungeons

Some dungeons are old strongholds abandoned by the folk who built them. Others are natural caves or lairs carved out by monsters. Dungeons attract cults, groups of monsters, and reclusive creatures. Because of their varied origins and purposes, dungeons have a range of distinctive qualities. For example, a dungeon that serves as a stronghold for hobgoblin soldiers has a different mood and features than an ancient temple inhabited by yuan-ti.

You can use the Dungeon Quirks table to add distinctive character to a dungeon you're creating or one in a published adventure. The quirks on the table reflect the characteristics of a dungeon's creator, its intended purpose, its location, or some (often catastrophic) event in its history. You can use a single quirk or combine quirks as you see fit, and roll or choose a result that inspires you.

Dungeon Quirks

1d100	Quirk
01–02	Abandoned after internal strife devastated its population
03–04	Abandoned because the site was cursed by a god or other powerful entity
05–06	Abandoned by its original creators when a plague spread through the dungeon
07–09	Amazingly well preserved ancient city inside a dome encased in volcanic ash, submerged underwater, or entombed in desert sands
10–12	Built as a fortress guarding a mountain pass
13–15	Built as a maze, either to protect treasure from intruders or as a gauntlet where prisoners were hunted by monsters
16–18	Built as a stronghold but abandoned after it fell to invaders
19–21	Built as a treasure vault to protect powerful magic items and great wealth
22–23	Built atop a cloud
24–26	Built beneath a city in catacombs or sewers
27–29	Built beneath or on top of a mesa or several connected mesas
30–32	Built by a religious group to serve as a temple and linked to the energy of other planes of existence
33–35	Built by dwarves and decorated with enormous dwarven faces that have been defaced by its current inhabitants
36–38	Built in a volcano
39–40	Built in or among the branches of a tree
41–43	Built to house a planar portal but abandoned when creatures or energy from the other side of the portal seeped into the dungeon
44–46	Carved into a meteorite (before or after it fell to earth)
47–49	Carved into a sheer cliff face
50–52	Caverns carved by a beholder's disintegration eye ray, with unnaturally smooth walls and vertical shafts connecting different levels
53–55	Contains something that led to the downfall of its creators or inhabitants
56–58	Dug as a burrow by a monster that might still live inside
59–61	Entrance concealed behind a waterfall
62–64	Floating on the sea
65–66	Intended as a death trap to eliminate any creature that enters, perhaps to guard a treasure or to harvest souls for a necromantic rite
67–69	Intended as a tomb
70–72	Long known as the site of a great miracle or another auspicious event
73–75	Made by amphibious creatures (such as kuo-toa or aboleths), using water to protect the innermost reaches from air-breathing intruders
76–78	Made by a powerful spellcaster (perhaps a lich) as a site for magical research and experimentation
79–81	Made by giants at a vast scale
82–84	Natural caverns featuring a range of strikingly beautiful rock and crystal formations
85–87	On an island in an underground sea
88–90	On the back of a Gargantuan creature
91–93	Originally constructed as a mine but abandoned when tunnels connected to dangerous Underdark tunnels
94–96	Secreted away in a demiplane or in a pocket dimension
97–98	Slowly abandoned as its creators died out or migrated away
99–00	Transformed by multiple events or disasters over the course of centuries



A DUNGEON BUILT BY GIANTS OFFERS ENORMOUS ADVENTURES.

Mapping a Dungeon

A dungeon can range in size from a few chambers to a huge complex of rooms and passages extending hundreds of feet. The adventurers' goal often lies as far from the dungeon entrance as possible, forcing characters to delve deeper underground or push farther into the heart of the complex.

A dungeon is usually mapped on a grid like graph paper, with each square on the paper representing an area of 5 feet by 5 feet. Appendix B shows several examples. If you play with miniatures on a grid, this scale makes it easy to transfer a map to a battle grid.

Mapping Principles

As you draw or adapt a dungeon map, keep the following in mind.

Asymmetry. Asymmetrical rooms and map layouts make a dungeon interesting and unpredictable.

Three-Dimensional Layout. Stairs, ramps, lifts, platforms, ledges, balconies, pits, and other changes of elevation make a dungeon interesting and make combat encounters in those areas challenging.

Multiple Pathways. Add multiple entrances and exits—to the dungeon as a whole and to individual rooms. By offering multiple paths the characters can follow, you present meaningful decision points to the players.

Wear and Tear. If you'd like to show wear and tear caused by time or the elements, collapsed passages can be commonplace, cutting off formerly connected sections of the dungeon from each other. Past earthquakes might have opened chasms within a dungeon, splitting rooms and corridors to make interesting obstacles.

Natural Features. Many dungeons include natural features. An underground stream might run through the middle of a stronghold, causing variation in the shapes and sizes of rooms and necessitating features such as bridges and drains.

Secrets. Add secret doors and secret rooms to reward players who take the time to search for them. For each door and room, consider their original purpose: were secret doors a defense against invaders, or do denizens of the dungeon scheme to keep secrets from each other? Secrets can help you develop the story of a dungeon.

Designing Dungeon Rooms

Keep the following things in mind when designing a dungeon room:

Ceiling Support. Underground chambers are prone to collapse, so many rooms—particularly large ones—have arched ceilings or pillars to support the weight of the rock overhead.

Decoration. Most sapient creatures decorate their lairs. Statues, bas-reliefs, murals, and mosaics often adorn dungeon rooms. Equally common are scrawled messages, marks, and maps left behind by others who have passed through the area. Some of these marks are simply graffiti, while others may be useful to adventurers who examine them closely.

Exits. Creatures that can't open doors can't make a lair in a sealed room without some sort of external assistance. Strong creatures without the ability to open doors smash them down if necessary. Burrowing creatures might dig their own exits.

Common dungeon rooms fall into the broad categories described below.

Crypts

Although it sometimes resembles a vault, a crypt can also be a series of individual rooms, each with its own sarcophagus, or a long hall with recesses on either side to hold coffins or bodies.

Crypt builders who are worried about undead rising from the grave lock and trap crypts from the outside—making the crypts easy to get into but difficult to exit. Other builders worried about tomb robbers make their crypts difficult to get into. Some builders make both entry and exit difficult, just to be safe.

Guard Posts

Sapient, social denizens of the dungeon generally guard the entrances to their shared spaces. A guard post may just be a room with a table where bored sentries play a dice game, or it might be a pair of iron golems backed up by spellcasters hiding in balconies overhead.

When you design a guard post, decide how many guards are on duty, note their Passive Perception scores, and decide what they do when they notice intruders (see "Monster Behavior" in chapter 4). Some will rush headlong into a fight, while others will negotiate, sound an alarm, or flee to get help.

Living Quarters

Most creatures have a lair where they can rest, eat, and store their treasure. Living quarters commonly include beds (if the creatures sleep), possessions (both valuable and mundane), and some sort of food preparation area (anything from a well-stocked kitchen to a firepit to a hunk of rotting meat).

Natural Subterranean Areas

Built dungeons often intersect with natural caverns, grottoes, and passages that are home to subterranean creatures, strange rock formations, pools of water, molds, fungi, and bioluminescent moss.

Shrines

Any sapient creature might have some place dedicated to worship. Depending on the creature's resources and piety, such a shrine can be humble or extensive. Adventurers are likely to encounter priests, cultists, and similar creatures there, and wounded monsters might flee to a shrine to seek healing.

Vaults

A vault contains treasure and is usually sealed behind a locked or secret door. Many vaults are further protected by magic, monsters that can survive without food and water, and traps (see "Traps" in this chapter).

Work Areas

Sapient creatures often have laboratories, workshops, libraries, forges, and studios. Because such areas tend to contain valuable equipment, their doors are often locked and sometimes even warded by *Glyph of Warding* spells and similar effects.

Dungeon Decay

The States of Ruin table can help you determine the general conditions of a dungeon area.

States of Ruin

1d6	Features
1	**Perilous.** The area is dangerously worn and prone to collapse. Any impacts or damage to the structure, including from spells and other areas of effect, have a 50 percent chance of causing a collapse.
2	**Crumbling.** Areas within the dungeon section are choked with rubble and have a 50 percent chance of being Difficult Terrain. Half Cover and hiding places are plentiful.
3	**Neglected.** One dungeon hazard—such as brown mold, green slime, or yellow mold (see "Hazards" in this chapter)—is abundant.
4	**Abandoned.** Most of the dungeon is deserted. Dexterity (Stealth) checks have Disadvantage because any sounds stand out as unusual.
5	**Secure.** Ability checks made to break down doors, open locks, or carry out similar activities have Disadvantage.
6	**Thriving.** The dungeon is heavily populated. Any loud noises draw the attention of nearby creatures.



A friendly bronze dragon keeps a watchful eye on a storm-tossed ship.

Environmental Effects

Characters crossing a frigid tundra might suffer the effects of extreme cold, while a visit to a cloud giant's castle might subject characters to the effects of high altitude. The following sections provide rules for handling these and other environmental effects.

Dead Magic Zone

A dead magic zone is an area where the fabric of magic is torn. The effect is the same as the *Antimagic Field* spell, except that it is permanent and typically covers an area no more than 300 feet in diameter.

Deep Water

Swimming through deep water (more than 100 feet deep) presents additional challenges because of the water's pressure and cold temperature. After each hour of swimming in deep water, a creature that lacks a Swim Speed must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw or gain 1 Exhaustion level.

Extreme Cold

When the temperature is 0 degrees Fahrenheit or lower, a creature exposed to the extreme cold must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw at the end of each hour or gain 1 Exhaustion level. Creatures that have Resistance or Immunity to Cold damage automatically succeed on the save.

Extreme Heat

When the temperature is 100 degrees Fahrenheit or higher, a creature exposed to the extreme heat and without access to drinkable water must succeed on a Constitution saving throw at the end of each hour or gain 1 Exhaustion level. The DC is 5 for the first hour and increases by 1 for each additional hour. Creatures wearing Medium or Heavy armor have Disadvantage on the save. Creatures that have Resistance or Immunity to Fire damage automatically succeed on the save.

Frigid Water

A creature can be immersed in frigid water for a number of minutes equal to its Constitution score before suffering any ill effects. Each additional minute spent in frigid water requires the creature to succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw or gain 1 Exhaustion level. Creatures with Resistance or Immunity to Cold damage automatically succeed on the save, as do creatures that are naturally adapted to living in ice-cold water.

Heavy Precipitation

Everything within an area of heavy rain or heavy snowfall is Lightly Obscured, and creatures in the area have Disadvantage on all Wisdom (Perception) checks. Heavy rain also extinguishes open flames.

High Altitude

Traveling at altitudes of 10,000 feet or higher above sea level is taxing for most creatures because of the reduced amount of oxygen in the air. Each hour such a creature spends traveling at high altitude counts as 2 hours for the purpose of determining how long that creature can travel (see "Travel Pace" in chapter 2).

Creatures can become acclimated to a high altitude by spending 30 days or more at this elevation. Creatures can't become acclimated to elevations above 20,000 feet unless they are native to such environments.

Planar Effects

Certain planes of existence—and areas on the Material Plane affected by them—have supernatural effects on creatures within them. Several examples are presented below. See chapter 6 for more information about the planes of existence.

Acheronian Bloodlust

The plane of Acheron rewards a creature for harming other creatures by imbuing it with the strength to keep fighting. While in Acheron or a region under its influence, a creature gains Temporary Hit Points equal to half its Hit Point maximum whenever it reduces another creature to 0 Hit Points.

Arcadian Vitality

On the plane of Arcadia and in regions where its influence is felt, creatures benefit from supernatural vitality, which grants them Immunity to the Frightened and Poisoned conditions.

Blessed Beneficence

On the plane of Mount Celestia and in regions where its influence is felt, creatures are blessed by the pervasive beneficence of the plane. Creatures other than Fiends and Undead gain the benefit of the *Bless* spell as long as they remain in an area of blessed beneficence. In addition, such a creature that finishes a Long Rest in the area gains the benefit of a *Lesser Restoration* spell.

Gehennan Cruelty

On the plane of Gehenna and in regions where its influence is felt, creatures are driven to loathe helping one another. Whenever a creature subject to Gehennan cruelty casts a spell that restores Hit Points or removes a condition other than Invisible, the caster must succeed on a DC 10 Charisma saving throw, or the spell fails and is wasted.

Winds of Pandemonium

The winds of Pandemonium are common in Pandemonium and regions where its influence is felt, including parts of the Underdark. A creature makes a DC 10 Wisdom saving throw after each hour spent among the howling winds. On a failed save, the creature gains 1 Exhaustion level. The winds can't increase a creature's Exhaustion level above 3. Finishing a Long Rest doesn't reduce a creature's Exhaustion level unless the creature can somehow escape the winds.

Slippery Ice

Slippery ice is Difficult Terrain. A creature that moves onto slippery ice for the first time on a turn or starts its turn there must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or have the Prone condition.

Strong Wind

Strong wind imposes Disadvantage on ranged attack rolls with weapons. It also extinguishes open flames and disperses fog. A flying creature in a strong wind must land at the end of its turn or fall.

A strong wind in a desert can create a sandstorm that imposes Disadvantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks.

Thin Ice

Thin ice has a weight tolerance of 3d10 × 10 pounds per 10-foot-square area. Whenever the total weight on an area of thin ice exceeds its tolerance, the ice in that area breaks. All creatures on broken ice fall through. Below the ice is frigid water (see "Frigid Water" above).

Wild Magic Zone

A past magical disaster or uncontrolled surge of power in a particular place can cause the fabric of magic to unravel, creating a wild magic zone. In such an area, which is typically no more than 300 feet in diameter, magic behaves unpredictably.

Whenever a creature expends a spell slot to cast a spell in a wild magic zone, roll 1d20. If you roll a 20 on the die, roll on the Wild Magic Surge table in the *Player's Handbook* to create a magical effect.

Fear and Mental Stress

Due to the nature of their vocation, adventurers tend to be less susceptible to fear and mental stress than common folk. Whereas a farmer might flee in terror from a bear or an apparition, adventurers are made of sterner stuff. That said, certain creatures and game effects can terrify or fray the mind of even the most stalwart adventurer.

If you plan to use any of these rules, discuss them with your players at the start of the campaign. See "Ensuring Fun for All" in chapter 1.

Fear Effects

Whenever the characters encounter something that is supernaturally frightful, use the Frightened condition as the baseline effect. Fear effects typically require a Wisdom saving throw, with a save DC based on how terrifying the situation is. The Sample Fear DCs table provides some examples.

Sample Fear DCs

Example	Save DC
When the characters open a sarcophagus, a harmless yet terrifying apparition appears.	10
A character triggers a magical trap that creates an illusory manifestation of that character's worst fears, visible only to that character.	15
A portal to the Abyss opens, revealing a nightmarish realm of torment and slaughter.	20

Typically, a Frightened creature repeats the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on itself on a success.

At your discretion, a Frightened creature might be subject to other effects as long as the Frightened condition lasts. Consider these examples:

- The Frightened creature must take the Dash action on each of its turns and uses its movement to get farther away from the source of its fear.
- Attack rolls against the Frightened creature have Advantage.
- The Frightened creature can do only one of the following on each of its turns: move, take an action, or take a Bonus Action.

Mental Stress Effects

When a character is subjected to an effect that causes intense mental stress, Psychic damage is the best way to emulate that effect.

The Sample Mental Stress Effects table provides a few examples of such effects, with suggested saving throw DCs and damage. Mental stress can usually be resisted with a successful Wisdom save, but sometimes an Intelligence or Charisma save is more appropriate. On a successful save, a character might take half as much damage instead of no damage, at your discretion.

Sample Mental Stress Effects

Example	Save DC	Psychic Damage
A character ingests a hallucinogenic substance that distorts the character's perception of reality.	10	1d6
A character touches a fiendish idol that tears at the character's mind, threatening to shatter it.	15	3d6
A magical trap flings a character into the Far Realm until the end of that character's next turn.	20	9d6

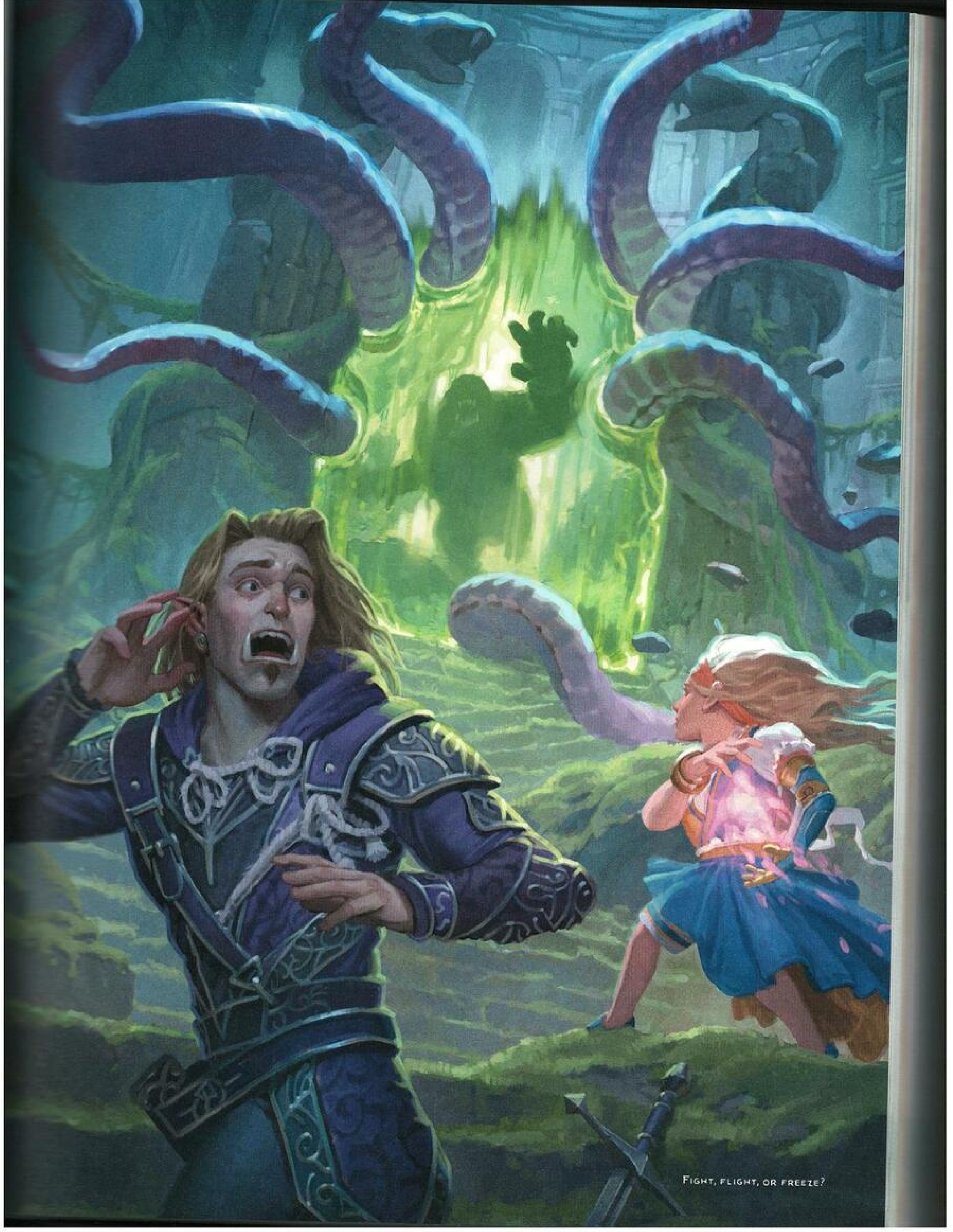
Prolonged Effects

Exposure to mental stress can cause prolonged effects. Consider the following possibilities.

Short-Term Effects. The character has the Frightened, Incapacitated, or Stunned condition for 1d10 minutes. This condition might be accompanied by alarming behavior or hallucinations. These effects can be suppressed with the *Calm Emotions* spell or removed by the *Lesser Restoration* spell.

Long-Term Effects. The character has Disadvantage on some or all ability checks for 1d10 × 10 hours, stemming from an unwillingness or inability to exert a particular set of abilities. The character might feel enervated and unable to exert much Strength, for example, or become so suspicious of others that Charisma checks are more difficult. These effects can be suppressed with the *Calm Emotions* spell or removed by the *Lesser Restoration* spell.

Indefinite Effects. An indefinite effect is a long-term effect (see above) that lasts until removed by a *Greater Restoration* spell. It can be suppressed by a *Calm Emotions* spell.


Fight, flight, or freeze?



When faced with a troll, there's no time to figure out the right way to hold a shotgun.

Firearms and Explosives

Renaissance-era pistols and muskets appear in the *Player's Handbook*. In a campaign involving a crashed spaceship or elements of modern-day Earth, characters might find the items described here.

Firearms

The Firearms table provides examples of modern and futuristic firearms. If you make them available for purchase (perhaps in the fantastical marketplaces of the City of Brass), treat modern items as Rare magic items and futuristic items as Very Rare ones (see chapter 7).

Properties

Some weapons in the Firearms table have the following properties, in addition to properties described in the *Player's Handbook*.

Burst Fire. As an action, you can expend 10 pieces of a Burst Fire weapon's ammunition to spray shots in a 10-foot Cube within the weapon's normal range. Each creature in that area must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or take damage. Roll the weapon's damage once, and apply it to each creature that failed the save.

Reload. You can make a limited number of shots with a Reload weapon. You must then reload the weapon as an action or a Bonus Action.

Ammunition

Firearm Bullets are destroyed upon use in a modern firearm. Futuristic firearms use Energy Cells that become depleted but could possibly be recharged with the proper equipment, at your discretion. An Energy Cell weighs 1/2 lb.

Explosives

The Explosives table has examples of explosives. If no cost is given for an explosive, it can't typically be bought. If you make these explosives available for purchase, treat them as Rare magic items. Rules for explosives are given below.

Bomb

As an action, you can light a Bomb and throw it at a point up to 60 feet away, where it explodes. Each creature in a 5-foot-radius Sphere centered on that point makes a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw, taking 3d6 Fire damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Dynamite Stick

An an action, you can light a Dynamite Stick and throw it at a point up to 60 feet away, where it explodes. Each creature in a 5-foot-radius Sphere centered on that point makes a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw, taking 3d6 Force damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Firearms

Modern Item	Damage	Properties	Mastery	Weight
Martial Ranged Weapons				
Automatic Rifle	2d8 Piercing	Ammunition (Range 80/240; Bullet), Burst Fire, Reload (30 shots), Two-Handed	Slow	8 lb.
Hunting Rifle	2d10 Piercing	Ammunition (Range 80/240; Bullet), Reload (5 shots), Two-Handed	Slow	8 lb.
Revolver	2d8 Piercing	Ammunition (Range 40/120; Bullet), Reload (6 shots)	Sap	3 lb.
Semiautomatic Pistol	2d6 Piercing	Ammunition (Range 50/150; Bullet), Reload (15 shots)	Vex	3 lb.
Shotgun	2d8 Piercing	Ammunition (Range 30/90; Bullet), Reload (2 shots), Two-Handed	Push	7 lb.

Futuristic Item	Damage	Properties	Mastery	Weight
Martial Ranged Weapons				
Antimatter Rifle	6d8 Necrotic	Ammunition (Range 120/360; Energy Cell), Reload (2 shots), Two-Handed	Sap	10 lb.
Laser Pistol	3d6 Radiant	Ammunition (Range 40/120; Energy Cell), Reload (50 shots)	Vex	2 lb.
Laser Rifle	3d8 Radiant	Ammunition (Range 100/300; Energy Cell), Reload (30 shots), Two-Handed	Slow	7 lb.

It takes 1 minute to bind two or more Dynamite Sticks together so they explode at the same time. Each stick after the first increases the damage by 1d6 (to a maximum of 10d6) and the effect's radius by 5 feet (to a maximum of 20 feet).

It takes 1 minute to rig dynamite with a longer fuse so it explodes after a longer period of time, such as 1 minute or 10 minutes.

Grenades and Grenade Launchers

As an action, you can either throw a grenade at a point up to 60 feet away or use a Grenade Launcher to propel the grenade to a point up to 1,000 feet away. The grenade explodes at that point, creating a particular effect in a 20-foot-radius Sphere.

Fragmentation Grenade. Each creature in the Sphere makes a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw, taking 17 (5d6) Piercing damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Smoke Grenade. The area of the Sphere is Heavily Obscured by smoke for 1 minute. A strong wind (such as the *Gust of Wind* spell) disperses the smoke.

Gunpowder

Setting fire to a container full of Gunpowder causes it to explode. When a container explodes, each creature in a 10-foot-radius Sphere centered on the container makes a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw, taking 10 (3d6) Fire damage (for a powder horn) or 24 (7d6) Fire damage (for a keg) on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Explosives

Item	Cost	Weight
Bomb	100 GP	1 lb.
Dynamite Stick	—	1 lb.
Grenade, Fragmentation	—	1 lb.
Grenade Launcher	—	7 lb.
Grenade, Smoke	50 GP	2 lb.
Gunpowder (keg)	250 GP	20 lb.
Gunpowder (powder horn)	35 GP	2 lb.

Alien Technology

When adventurers find a piece of technology that isn't from their world or time period, they can deduce what it is with a successful Intelligence (Investigation) check, with the DC depending on the complexity of the item: DC 10 for a relatively simple item like a calculator or a lighter, or DC 20 for a complex item such as a computer, a chainsaw, or a hovercraft. You may require a separate Intelligence (Investigation) check to determine whether a character can activate or operate the technology; a character who has observed the item in use or has operated a similar item either has Advantage on the check or succeeds on the check automatically (your choice).

Gods and Other Powers

Different deities rule the various aspects of the cosmos and mortal life, sometimes cooperating with each other, sometimes competing. People gather in public shrines to worship gods of life and wisdom or meet in hidden places to venerate gods of deception or destruction.

Divine Rank

The divine beings of the multiverse are often categorized according to their relative cosmic power. Some gods who are worshiped on multiple worlds have a different rank on each world, depending on their influence there.

Greater deities are generally the oldest gods of a pantheon, responsible (at least in myth) for creating or parenting the other gods. Their provinces are major areas of nature and mortal life, such as agriculture, the sun, and death. Greater deities are ultimately beyond mortal understanding, and they're often known by different names across regions, cultures, and worlds. Having no fixed appearance or gender, they can assume whatever forms they like. Occasionally these deities manifest and perform mythic deeds among mortals.

Lesser deities are typically described in myth as the creations, children, or servitors of the greater deities. They govern narrower provinces, such as the activities of mortal life or limited aspects of the natural world. They share the fundamentally ineffable nature of greater gods, but they are more likely to manifest in mortal realms.

Quasi-deities have a divine origin, but they don't receive or answer prayers. They are still immensely powerful beings, and in theory, they could ascend to godhood if they amass enough worshipers. Quasi-deities fall into the following subcategories:

Demigods are divine beings with mortal origin. Some were born mortal and attained godhood, while others were born from the union of a deity and a mortal. Their mortal parentage makes demigods the weakest quasi-deities.

Titans are the creations of deities. They might be manufactured on a divine forge, born from the blood spilled by a god, or otherwise brought about through divine will or substance. Some titans, including krakens and the tarrasque, appear in the *Monster Manual*.

Vestiges are deities who have lost nearly all their worshipers and are considered dead from a mortal perspective. Esoteric rituals can sometimes contact vestiges and draw on their latent power.

Build Your Own Pantheon

Most of the published D&D settings described in chapter 5 have their own pantheons of gods. If you're creating your own setting, you can use the list of Greyhawk gods in chapter 5 or build your own pantheon.

A simple way to build a basic pantheon is to create one god for each of the Outer Planes described in chapter 6, except for the Nine Hells (ruled by the archdevil Asmodeus) and the Abyss (the domain of demons). So Arborea might be the domain of a god who is patron of the arts, celebrated at great feasts, while Gehenna's deity might be a greedy, vengeful god worshiped by people of the same bent. If you prefer, you can also put multiple deities on the same plane, so Arcadia might be home to twin gods who are patrons of merchants and smiths.

Alternatively, you might decide that your world has only one god (who might be viewed differently by various sects or religions) or one good god and one evil god. Or your world might be alive with spirits great and small, from lesser river spirits to the godlike spirits who inhabit great mountains. Impersonal forces and philosophies can also fill the role of gods in a campaign.

Home Plane and Alignment

Gods aren't defined by mortal conceptions of alignment, and different mortal worshipers might interpret a god's behavior and teachings through the lens of different alignments. That said, gods tend to live on the Outer Planes that most closely match their general alignment tendencies, so it's safe to assume that the teachings of a god who resides in Pandemonium (a plane of rampant chaos and evil), encourage behavior that is Chaotic Evil, while a god who resides in Elysium (the plane of pure good) encourages Neutral Good behavior.

People can worship a god without obeying that god's tenets or conforming to the god's presumed alignment. People from all walks of life might participate in the annual festival of innocent mischief associated with a trickster god—even people whose alignment is generally lawful and opposed to the trickster's teachings. To stave off disease, good-hearted people might make offerings to appease the wrath of a god associated with plague. Even Cleric characters don't need to have any particular alignment to serve their gods.

Gods and Divine Magic

Divine magic—which includes the spells cast by Clerics, Druids, Paladins, and Rangers—is mediated through beings and forces that are categorized as divine. These can include gods but also include the primal forces of nature, the beneficent power of

ancestral spirits, the sacred weight of a Paladin's oath, and impersonal principles or entities such as Fate or the order of the universe. These beings and forces grant characters the power to wield the magic of their planar domains.

For game purposes, wielding divine power isn't dependent on the gods' ongoing approval or the strength of a character's devotion. The power is a gift offered to a select few; once given, it can't be rescinded.

That said, characters' relationships with the divine forces they access to wield their magic, much like Warlocks' relationships with their patrons, are ripe for exploration. A Cleric might accompany every casting of a spell with a litany of complaints directed at the gods. The Paladin class description in the *Player's Handbook* offers some suggestions for how a player might roleplay a situation where their Paladin has broken their oath. You can also decide how NPCs react to a character whose behavior doesn't square with the ideals implied by the Holy Symbol the character wears.

Divine Knowledge

The *Commune* spell allows its caster to ask a deity (or an agent of the god) yes-or-no questions and receive correct information, and other spells of the Divination school have similar effects. As the *Commune* spell description states, gods aren't necessarily omniscient. But they are tremendously knowledgeable, particularly with regard to their particular areas of influence. A sea god can be reasonably expected to know anything that has happened in or on a sea, for example, and a martial god knows details about wars. Gods can reliably predict the future, at least in the short term (hence their ability to answer spells such as *Augury* and *Divination*). And some gods might be unwilling to reveal their ignorance, choosing to give an unclear answer rather than admit that they don't know the truth.

Divine Intervention

In some campaigns, gods are fond of meddling in mortal affairs, and heroes sometimes call on the gods for aid beyond what divine magic ordinarily provides. The gods sometimes also send dreams, omens, or emissaries to direct mortals along a certain path. Keep these two principles in mind to guide your use of divine intervention in your campaign:

Don't Eliminate Character Choice. The gods can tell characters to do things and even threaten to punish them if they don't do things, but the gods can't control mortal actions.

Don't Eliminate Risk and Danger. The intervention of a god should never guarantee success or victory, nor should a god's interference portend immediate defeat. Gods can act to change the balance of an encounter or offer an avenue of escape, but they count on mortal heroes to act like heroes.

With those principles in mind, you might have gods intervene in dire situations in one of these ways:

Blessings. A god might bestow a Blessing (see "Supernatural Gifts" in this chapter) to help a character in need.

Emissaries. A god might send a Celestial, a Fiend, or some other kind of emissary to aid a character with information, guidance, or combat.

Miracles. As the simplest form of miracle, a god can produce the effect of any spell that devotees of that god might cast (typically Cleric or Druid spells). But a god's direct intervention can take any form you choose, often reflecting the god's nature.

Creating Religions

A list of gods is a good starting point, and it can be sufficient to get a campaign started. But you can add more depth to your campaign world by fleshing out more details of religious belief and practice.

Myths

Stories about the gods explore their relationships with each other, with the natural world, and with the realm of mortals. Myths might describe familial relationships among the gods, deeds of creation, past interactions with mortals, or battles between gods and other cosmic forces. Given the incomprehensible nature of the gods, these myths might not actually reveal anything about the gods, but they certainly describe people's understanding of their own place in relation to the gods.

Religious Practice

People honor multiple gods of a pantheon in different circumstances. A person might burn incense to a hearth or family deity at a kitchen altar in the morning, pray to a deity of the hunt while hunting in the afternoon, and join a communal harvest feast at the temple of an agricultural deity in the evening.

Cities and large towns can host numerous temples dedicated to individual gods important to the community, while smaller settlements might have a single shrine devoted to any gods the locals revere. Temples and shrines outside settlements often mark places where a god (or the manifestation of a god) appeared or caused a miracle. These sites can become the focus of pilgrims who travel long distances to partake in the holy power assumed to linger there.

Hazards

The *Player's Handbook* describes common hazards that adventurers encounter, such as falling and dehydration. This section details some unusual hazards you can add to a location to make it more challenging.

Severity and Level

Each hazard in this section is designated as a nuisance or as deadly for characters of certain levels. A nuisance hazard is unlikely to seriously harm characters of the indicated levels, whereas a deadly hazard can grievously damage characters of the indicated levels.

Use caution when introducing a hazard to characters of a level lower than the hazard's level range. A hazard that is a nuisance at one level range could be deadly to characters in the next-lower range.

Example Hazards

Hazards are presented in alphabetical order.

Brown Mold

Deadly Hazard (Levels 5–10) or Nuisance Hazard (Levels 11–16)

Brown mold resembles a furry, light-brown carpet. This fungus feeds on warmth, drawing heat from anything around itself. One patch of brown mold covers a 10-foot square, and the temperature within 30 feet of it is always frigid.

When a creature enters a space within 5 feet of the mold for the first time on a turn or starts its turn there, the creature makes a DC 12 Constitution saving throw, taking 22 (4d10) Cold damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Brown mold has Immunity to Fire damage, and any source of fire brought within 5 feet of it causes the mold to instantly expand across a surface and toward the fire, creating a new patch that covers a 10-foot square. A patch of brown mold exposed to an effect that deals any amount of Cold damage is destroyed instantly.

Fireball Fungus

Deadly Hazard (Levels 5–10)

A fireball fungus is a Small, inanimate mushroom that can grow anywhere fungi are found in abundance. Its luminous, orange cap sheds Bright Light in a 15-foot radius and Dim Light for an additional 15 feet.

A fireball fungus has AC 10, HP 6, and Immunity to Psychic damage. When it drops to 0 Hit Points, the fungus explodes as if a *Fireball* spell (save DC 15) had been centered on it.

At Higher Levels. The explosion of a fireball fungus causes other fireball fungi in the area of effect to explode as well. You can scale the hazard for higher levels by adding one additional fungus at levels 11–16 or three additional fungi at levels 17–20.

Green Slime

Nuisance Hazard (Levels 1–4)

Acidic green slime devours flesh, organic material, and metal on contact. Bright green, wet, and sticky, it clings to walls, floors, and ceilings in patches.

One patch of green slime covers a 5-foot square. Green slime has Blindsight with a range of 30 feet, and it drops from walls and ceilings when it detects movement below itself. Beyond that, it can't move. A creature aware of the slime's presence can avoid being struck by it with a successful DC 10 Dexterity saving throw.

A creature that comes in contact with green slime takes 5 (1d10) Acid damage. The creature takes the damage again at the start of each of its turns until the slime is scraped off (requiring an action) or destroyed. Against wood or metal, green slime deals 11 (2d10) Acid damage each round, and any nonmagical wood or metal item used to scrape off the green slime is destroyed.

Direct sunlight or any amount of Cold, Fire, or Radiant damage destroys a patch of green slime.

Inferno

Deadly Hazard (Levels 5–10) or Nuisance Hazard (Levels 11–16)

Whenever an uncontrolled fire spreads, it can create an inferno that quickly engulfs creatures, objects, and vegetation.

An inferno consists of at least four contiguous 10-foot Cubes of fire. Each of the inferno's 10-foot Cubes can be doused with 10 gallons of water. Exposure to a strong wind for 1 minute causes the inferno to grow, adding 1d4 new 10-foot Cubes to its volume. An inferno deprived of fuel burns itself out after 1d10 minutes.

An inferno damages any vegetation or object that isn't being worn or carried that it touches, dealing 22 (4d10) Fire damage immediately and again at the end of each minute. Any creature that enters the inferno for the first time on a turn or starts its turn there takes 22 (4d10) Fire damage and is burning.



Sheila discovers that green slime is more dangerous than it looks.

Poisonous Gas

Nuisance Hazard (Levels 1–4)

Poisonous gas is usually encountered in an enclosed space, such as a sewer or sealed tomb. The gas fills as much space as it can, up to a maximum of ten 10-foot Cubes. The transparent gas carries a foul odor. The gas is continuously or periodically replenished by some natural or magical source, though a strong wind disperses the gas for 1 minute.

Any creature that enters poisonous gas for the first time on a turn or starts its turn there makes a DC 12 Constitution saving throw, taking 5 (1d10) Poison damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one. Creatures in the gas also have Disadvantage on Death Saving Throws.

At Higher Levels. You can scale the hazard for higher levels by increasing the Poison damage and the save DC, as shown in the following table.

Levels	Poison Damage	Save DC
5–10	11 (2d10)	14
11–16	22 (4d10)	16
17–20	55 (10d10)	18

Quicksand Pit

Nuisance Hazard (Levels 1–4)

A quicksand pit is 10 feet deep and covers the ground in a 10-foot square. A creature that enters the area sinks 1d4 + 1 feet into the quicksand and has the Restrained condition. At the start of each of the creature's turns, it sinks another 1d4 feet. As long as the creature isn't completely submerged in quicksand, it can take an action to try to escape, doing so with a successful Strength (Athletics) check (DC 10 plus the number of feet the creature has sunk into the quicksand). A creature that is completely submerged in quicksand has Total Cover and the Blinded condition and risks suffocation.

A creature can pull another creature within its reach out of a quicksand pit by taking an action and succeeding on a Strength (Athletics) check (DC 5 plus the number of feet the creature has sunk into the quicksand).

At Higher Levels. You can scale this hazard for higher levels by making the pit deeper and increasing the number of feet a creature sinks at the start of each of its turns, as shown in the following table.

Levels	Pit Depth	Sinking Rate
5–10	15 feet	1d6 feet
11–16	20 feet	1d8 feet
17–20	30 feet	1d10 feet

Razorvine

Nuisance Hazard (Levels 1–4)

Razorvine is a plant that grows in wild tangles and hedges. It also clings to the sides of buildings and other surfaces as ivy does. A 10-foot-high, 10-foot-wide, 5-foot-thick wall or hedge of razorvine has AC 11; HP 25; and Immunity to Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Psychic damage.

When a creature comes into contact with razorvine for the first time on a turn, the creature must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or take 5 (1d10) Slashing damage from the bladelike thorns.

River Styx

Nuisance Hazard (Levels 11–16)

The River Styx courses through the Lower Planes. Tasting or touching its waters can shatter a creature's intellect and personality, as well as strip away its memories. Certain Fiends are immune to the river's effects.

Unless immune to the river's effects, a creature that drinks from the Styx, enters the river, or starts its turn in the river makes a DC 20 Intelligence saving throw. On a failed save, the creature takes 19 (3d12) Psychic damage and can't cast spells or take the Magic action for 30 days. An affected creature can drink from the Styx and swim in its waters without suffering any additional effects.

The effect can be ended only by the *Greater Restoration*, *Heal*, or *Wish* spell. If the effect isn't ended after 30 days, the effect becomes permanent, and the creature loses all its memories. At that point, nothing short of a *Wish* spell or divine intervention can undo the effect.

Water taken from the River Styx loses its potency after 24 hours, becoming a harmless, foul-tasting liquid. Arcanaloths, night hags, and other fell creatures might know rituals that can prolong the water's potency, at your discretion.

Rockslide

Deadly Hazard (Levels 1–4)

When a rockslide occurs, every creature in its path makes a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw. On a failed save, a creature takes 11 (2d10) Bludgeoning damage, has the Prone condition, and moves with the rockslide. On a successful save, a creature takes half as much damage only.

When the rockslide stops, its space becomes Difficult Terrain, and all Prone creatures in its space are buried under rocks and debris. A creature buried in this way has the Restrained condition and has Total Cover. As an action, a creature can try to crawl out from under the rock pile. If the creature succeeds on a DC 15 Strength (Athletics) check, it is no longer Restrained; instead, it has the Prone condition and is atop the rock pile. If the check fails, the creature remains buried and gains 1 Exhaustion level.

A creature that has neither the Incapacitated nor the Restrained condition can spend 1 minute freeing another creature buried by the rockslide.

At Higher Levels. You can scale this hazard for higher levels by increasing the Bludgeoning damage as follows: 22 (4d10) at levels 5–10, 55 (10d10) at levels 11–16, and 99 (18d10) at levels 17–20.

Vicious Vine

Nuisance Hazard (Levels 1–4)

Vicious vines are animated by magic. They often cling to doorways, archways, walls, and statuary. Until a vicious vine moves, there's nothing to distinguish it from an inanimate vine.

Each vicious vine has AC 11; HP 16; and Immunity to Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Psychic damage. When a creature enters a space within 5 feet of the vine for the first time on a turn or starts its turn there, the vine tries to coil around that creature. The target must succeed on a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or have the Grappled condition (escape DC 12). While Grappled in this way, the target takes 5 (1d10) Necrotic damage from the vine's life-draining thorns at the start of each of the target's turns. The vine can grapple only one creature at a time.

As an Influence action, a character under the effect of a *Speak with Plants* spell or similar magic can try to persuade the vine to release its victim, doing so with a successful DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) check. A creature released by the vine in this way won't be attacked by that vine again for the next 24 hours.

At Higher Levels. You can scale the hazard for higher levels by increasing the Necrotic damage, the save DC, and the escape DC, as shown in the following table.

Levels	Necrotic Damage	Save/Escape DC
5–10	11 (2d10)	14
11–16	22 (4d10)	16
17–20	55 (10d10)	18



Webs

Nuisance Hazard (Levels 1–4)

Giant spiders weave thick, sticky webs across passages and at the bottom of pits to snare prey. These web-filled areas are Difficult Terrain.

A creature that enters a web-filled area for the first time on a turn or starts its turn there must succeed on a DC 12 Dexterity saving throw or have the Restrained condition. As an action, a creature Restrained by the webs can try to escape from them, doing so with a successful DC 12 Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) check.

Each 10-foot Cube of webs has AC 10; HP 15; Vulnerability to Fire damage; and Immunity to Piercing, Poison, and Psychic damage.

Yellow Mold

Deadly Hazard (Levels 1–4) or Nuisance Hazard (Levels 5–10)

Yellow mold grows in dark places, and one patch covers a 5-foot square. If touched, the mold ejects a cloud of spores that fills a 10-foot Cube. Any creature in that area must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or take 11 (2d10) Poison damage and have the Poisoned condition for 1 minute. While Poisoned in this way, the creature takes 5 (1d10) Poison damage at the start of each of its turns. The creature repeats the save at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on itself on a success.

Direct sunlight or any amount of Fire damage destroys a patch of yellow mold.



Marks of Prestige

Sometimes the most memorable reward for adventurers is the prestige they acquire throughout a realm. Their adventures often earn them fame and power, allies and enemies, and titles the adventurers can pass on to their descendants. This section details the most common marks of prestige that adventurers might acquire during a campaign.

The best rewards in an adventure are directly related to the circumstances of the adventure. For example, if a merchant hires the characters to retrieve a family heirloom from a long-abandoned tower, the merchant might give the deed to the tower as a reward.

Fortifications

A fortification is a reward usually given to seasoned adventurers who demonstrate unwavering fealty to a powerful political figure or ruling body, such as a monarch, a knighthood, or a council of wizards. A fortification can be anything from a fortress in the heart of a city to a provincial keep on the borderlands. While the fortification is for the characters to govern as they see fit, the land on which it sits remains the property of the crown or local ruler. Should the characters prove disloyal or unworthy of the gift, they can be asked or forced to relinquish custody of the fortification. In that respect, the fortification is different from the characters' Bastions (described in chapter 8). However, you can also use the gift of a fortification as a pretext for the characters acquiring their Bastions.

The individual bequeathing the fortification might offer to pay its maintenance costs for one or more months, after which the characters inherit that responsibility. The type of fortification determines its maintenance costs, as shown in the Maintenance Costs table.

Maintenance Costs

Fortification	Cost per Day
Fortified outpost or watchtower	50 GP
Keep or small castle	100 GP
Large castle or fortress	400 GP

Letters of Recommendation

A benefactor might provide adventurers with a letter of recommendation rather than payment. Such a letter is usually enclosed in a handsome folio, case, or scroll tube for safe transport, and it usually bears the signature and seal of whoever wrote it.

A letter of recommendation from a person of impeccable reputation can grant adventurers access to NPCs whom they would otherwise have trouble meeting, such as a duke, duchess, viceroy, or monarch. Moreover, carrying such a recommendation on one's person establish a baseline of trust with local authorities.



Queen Yolande of Celene is grateful for adventurers' aid.

A letter of recommendation is worth only as much as the reputation of the person who wrote it and offers no benefit where its writer holds no sway.

Medals

Although they are often fashioned from gold and other precious materials, medals have an even greater symbolic value to those who award and receive them. Medals are typically awarded by political figures for acts of heroism, and wearing a medal is usually enough to earn the respect of those who understand its significance.

Different acts of heroism can warrant different kinds of medals. The king of Breland (in the Eberron setting) might award a Royal Badge of Valor (shaped like a shield and made of ruby and electrum) to adventurers for defending Brelish citizens. The Golden Bear of Breland (a medal made of gold and shaped in a likeness of a bear's head, with gems for eyes) might be reserved for adventurers who prove their allegiance to the Brelish Crown.

A medal doesn't offer a specific in-game benefit to one who wears it, but it can affect dealings with NPCs. For example, a character who displays the Golden Bear of Breland is regarded as a hero of the people within the kingdom of Breland. Outside Breland, the medal carries far less weight, except among allies of Breland's king.

Parcels of Land

A parcel of land usually comes with a letter from a local ruler, affirming that the land has been granted as a reward for some service. Such land usually remains the property of the local ruler or ruling body but is lent to a character with the understanding that it can be taken away, especially if the character's loyalty is ever called into question.

Characters who receive a parcel of land are free to build on it and are expected to safeguard it. They may yield the land as part of an inheritance, but they can't sell or trade it without permission from the local ruler or ruling body. If a character already has a Bastion (see chapter 8), the parcel of land might surround the Bastion or be close to it.

Parcels of land make fine rewards for adventurers who are looking for a place to settle or who have family or a personal investment in the region where the land is located.

Special Favors

A reward might be a favor the characters can call on at some future date. Special favors work best when the individual granting them is trustworthy. A Lawful Good or Lawful Neutral NPC will do whatever can be done to fulfill an obligation when the time comes, short of breaking laws. A Lawful Evil NPC does the same, but only because a deal is a deal. A Neutral Good or Neutral NPC might pay off favors to protect their reputation. A Chaotic Good NPC is more concerned about doing right by the adventurers, honoring any obligations without worrying too much about personal risk or adherence to the law.

Special Rights

A politically powerful person can reward characters by giving them special rights, which might be articulated in some sort of official document or proclamation. For example, characters might be granted special rights to attack pirate ships or other enemies of the crown, to lead rites or ceremonies in a community, or to negotiate on a ruler's behalf. They might receive a lifetime of free room and board from the grateful citizens of a community or gain the sworn service of local soldiers to assist them as needed.

Special rights last only as long as the legal document dictates, and such rights can be revoked if the adventurers abuse them.

Titles

A politically powerful figure has the ability to dispense titles. A title often comes with a parcel of land (see above). For example, a character might be awarded the title Earl of Stormriver or Countess of Dun Fjord, along with a parcel of land that includes a settlement or region of the same name. Archfey are fond of granting whimsical (and alliterative) titles, such as Chancellor of Chocolates or Grand Duke of Giggles, which might come with minor supernatural gifts (see "Supernatural Gifts" in this chapter) rather than land.

A character can hold more than one title, and in a feudal society, those titles can be passed down to (or distributed among) one's children. A character who holds a title is expected to act in a manner befitting that title. By decree, titles can be stripped away if the character fails to meet the obligations and responsibilities that come with the title.

Training

A character might be offered special training. This kind of training isn't widely available and thus is highly desirable.

The character must spend 30 days with the trainer to receive a special benefit. Possible training benefits include the following:

- The character gains proficiency in a skill.
- The character gains proficiency with a tool.
- The character learns a language.

Mobs

This section can help you speed up play when resolving outcomes with large groups of monsters, also known as mobs.

Tips

Follow these tips to smooth a combat encounter with a large number of monsters:

Damage. Use the average damage specified in a monster's stat block.

Hit Points. If a spell or attack reduces a monster to a handful of Hit Points, assume the monster is killed or otherwise taken out of the fight.

Monster Mobs. Divide a large number of identical monsters into smaller mobs and spread their turns out between the characters' turns. Mobs of five to eight identical creatures work well, but don't have more mobs than there are characters.

Average Results

Whenever you would otherwise make a number of D20 Tests for identical monsters, the Mob Results table can help you determine the number of successful D20 Tests the monsters get without having to roll dice. Follow these steps:

Step 1. Determine the minimum d20 roll the monsters need to succeed on the D20 Test using the following formula:

Roll needed = target number – monster's bonus

Step 2. Find the roll needed on the Mob Results table. If all the monsters have Advantage on the roll (for example, if they're attacking and have the Pack Tactics trait, or if they're making a saving throw against a spell and have the Magic Resistance trait), find the roll needed in the With Advantage column. If all the monsters have Disadvantage (for example, if they're attacking a creature protected by the *Blur* spell), use the With Disadvantage column. Otherwise, use the Normal column.

Step 3. Read across the table to find a fractional number of successes you can easily apply to the group of monsters. That's the fraction of monsters that succeed on the D20 Test.

Adjudicating Areas of Effect

When the characters are fighting a large number of monsters, it's not always practical to use miniatures on a battle grid or some other visual aid. So how do you determine how many monsters are affected by the Wizard's *Fireball* spell or some other area of effect?

The Targets in Area of Effect table offers a guideline. To use the table, find the column for the shape of the area, then read down until you find its size. Then check the rightmost column to see about how many creatures are caught in the area. If you imagine that the targets are spread out, decrease the number by 1d3. If they're bunched up, you can increase the number by 1d3. Of course, an area can't encompass more creatures than are present in an encounter.

Your judgment always outweighs these guidelines, and it's fine to err on the side of affecting more creatures. For example, if eight zombies are crowded around a Fighter when the Bard centers a *Shatter* spell on the Fighter's space, the spell's area should definitely engulf all eight zombies, even though according to the table, a 10-foot-radius Sphere includes only three creatures.

Examples

The following scenario shows examples of how you as the DM can apply the guidelines described in the rest of this section.

Eight **Zombies** surround and attack a Fighter. The zombies' attack bonus is +3, and the Fighter's AC is 18, so the roll needed is 15 (18 - 3). Finding 15 in the Normal column and reading across to the Out of 8 column, the DM gets a result of 2/8—two of the zombies hit. Using the zombies' average damage (4 Bludgeoning damage), the Fighter takes 8 Bludgeoning damage.

After seeing the Fighter mauled by zombies, the Bard casts *Shatter*, centering the spell on the Fighter. (The Bard trusts that the Fighter will succeed on the Constitution saving throw and survive the resulting damage.) The spell affects a 10-foot-radius Sphere, and the Targets in Area of Effect table suggests that such an area should encompass three zombies. However, the DM decides that all eight zombies (and the Fighter) are affected. The zombies' Constitution saving throw bonus is +3, and the Bard's spell saving throw DC is 16, so the roll needed is 13 (16 - 3). Finding 13 in the Normal column and reading across to the Out of 8 column, the DM gets a result of 3/8, so three of the zombies succeed on their saving throws.

Seeing a larger crowd of zombies in the distance, the Wizard casts *Fireball*. The spell covers a 20-foot-radius Sphere. The Targets in Area of Effect table suggests that area covers ten zombies, but the DM rules that they're densely packed together and adds 1d3, rolling a 2. So the spell engulfs twelve zombies in its area. The zombies' Dexterity saving throw modifier is -2, and the Wizard's spell save DC is 16, so the roll needed is 18 (16 - [-2]). Finding 18 in the Normal column and reading across to the Out of 6 column, the DM gets a result of 1/6. Twelve times 1/6 is 2, so two of the twelve zombies succeed on the save.

Mob Results

Roll Needed			Number of Successes				
Normal	With Advantage	With Disadvantage	Out of 4	Out of 5	Out of 6	Out of 8	Out of 10
1	1–4	1	4/4	5/5	6/6	8/8	10/10
2	5–6	—	4/4	5/5	6/6	8/8	10/10
3	7–8	2	4/4	5/5	5/6	7/8	9/10
4	9	—	3/4	4/5	5/6	7/8	9/10
5	10	3	3/4	4/5	5/6	6/8	8/10
6	11	—	3/4	4/5	5/6	6/8	8/10
7	12	4	3/4	4/5	4/6	6/8	7/10
8	13	5	3/4	3/5	4/6	5/8	7/10
9	14	—	2/4	3/5	4/6	5/8	6/10
10	—	6	2/4	3/5	3/6	4/8	6/10
11	15	7	2/4	3/5	3/6	4/8	5/10
12	16	—	2/4	2/5	3/6	4/8	5/10
13	—	8	2/4	2/5	2/6	3/8	4/10
14	17	9	1/4	2/5	2/6	3/8	4/10
15	18	10	1/4	2/5	2/6	2/8	3/10
16	—	11	1/4	1/5	2/6	2/8	3/10
17	19	12	1/4	1/5	1/6	2/8	2/10
18	—	13	1/4	1/5	1/6	1/8	2/10
19	20	14–15	0	1/5	1/6	1/8	1/10
20	—	16–17	0	0	0	0	1/10

Targets in Area of Effect

Area Shape and Size				Number of Targets
Cone	Cube	Circular*	Line	
10-foot	5- to 10-foot	5-foot-radius	—	1
15- to 20-foot	15-foot	—	30-foot-long, 5-foot-wide	2
25-foot	—	10-foot-radius	30-foot-long, 10-foot-wide or 60-foot-long, 5-foot-wide	3
—	20-foot	—	90- or 100-foot-long, 5-foot-wide	4
30-foot	—	—	60-foot-long, 10-foot-wide or 120-foot-long, 5-foot-wide	5
35-foot	25-foot	15-foot-radius	—	6
40-foot	30-foot	—	90- or 100-foot-long, 10-foot-wide	8
45-foot	—	—	—	9
50-foot	35-foot	20-foot-radius	120-foot-long, 10-foot-wide	10
55-foot	40-foot	—	—	12
60-foot	45-foot	25-foot-radius	—	16
—	50-foot	30-foot-radius	—	20

*Use this column for Cylinders, Emanations (using the size of the Emanation rather than its radius), and Spheres.



Nonplayer Characters

Nonplayer characters (NPCs) are supporting characters controlled by you, the DM. Examples include the local innkeeper, the sage who lives in the tower on the outskirts of town, and the death knight out to destroy the kingdom.

The *Monster Manual* contains stat blocks you can use to represent NPCs in your game. You can add details to make them distinctive and memorable. For example, your players will have no trouble remembering the no-nonsense blacksmith with the tattoo of the black rose on her right shoulder or the badly dressed musician with the broken nose. NPCs in your game rarely need much more complexity than that.

Detailed NPCs

Flesh out NPCs who play prominent roles in your adventures. You can use the accompanying NPC Tracker to record information as you determine these six elements of your NPC:

Name	Alignment	Appearance
Stat Block	Personality	Secret

Name

You'll need a name for any NPC who plays a prominent role in your campaign. You can pick a given name and a surname from any of the accompanying tables; a name can include options from different tables. If you like, you can roll 1d6 to determine which table to choose a name from, then roll 1d12 to get a name. You can also alter or combine names, pull from a book of names, or use a name inspired by a movie or book.

Stat Block

Choose a stat block from the *Monster Manual* to represent the NPC's game statistics. You don't need to do this if you don't expect the NPC to engage in combat or use any special abilities (such as casting spells). You can customize the stat block using the guidelines under "Creating a Creature" in this chapter to better reflect the NPC you have in mind.

Alignment

Choose the NPC's alignment, which can help you sketch the outlines of an NPC's behavior and personality. See the *Player's Handbook* and "Alignment" in this chapter for more information.

1: Common Names

1d12	Common Given Name	Common Surname
1	Adrik	Brightsun
2	Alvyn	Dundragon
3	Aurora	Frostbeard
4	Eldeth	Garrick
5	Eldon	Goodbarrel
6	Farris	Greycastle
7	Kathra	Ironfist
8	Kellen	Jaerin
9	Lily	Merryweather
10	Nissa	Redthorn
11	Xinli	Stormriver
12	Zorra	Wren

2: Guttural Names

1d12	Guttural Given Name	Guttural Surname
1	Abzug	Burska
2	Bajok	Gruuthok
3	Bharash	Hrondl
4	Grovis	Jarzzok
5	Gruuna	Kraltus
6	Hokrun	Shamog
7	Mardred	Skrangval
8	Rhogar	Ungart
9	Skuldark	Uuthrakt
10	Thokk	Vrakir
11	Urzul	Yuldra
12	Varka	Zulrax

3: Lyrical Names

1d12	Lyrical Given Name	Lyrical Surname
1	Arannis	Arvannis
2	Damaia	Brawnanvil
3	Darsis	Daardendrian
4	Dweomer	Drachedandion
5	Evabeth	Endryss
6	Jhessail	Meliamne
7	Keyleth	Mishann
8	Netheria	Silverfrond
9	Orianna	Snowmantle
10	Sorcyl	Summerbreeze
11	Umarion	Thunderfoot
12	Velissa	Zashir

4: Monosyllabic Names

1d12	Monosyllabic Given Name	Monosyllabic Surname
1	Chen	Dench
2	Creel	Drog
3	Dain	Dusk
4	Dorn	Holg
5	Flint	Horn
6	Glim	Imsh
7	Henk	Jask
8	Krusk	Keth
9	Nox	Ku
10	Nyx	Kung
11	Rukh	Mott
12	Shan	Quaal

5: Sinister Names

1d12	Sinister Given Name	Sinister Surname
1	Arachne	Doomwhisper
2	Axyss	Dreadfield
3	Carrion	Gallows
4	Grinnus	Hellstryke
5	Melkhis	Killraven
6	Morthos	Nightblade
7	Nadir	Norixius
8	Scandal	Shadowfang
9	Skellendyre	Valtar
10	Thaltus	Winterspell
11	Valkora	Xandros
12	Vexander	Zarkynzorn

6: Whimsical Names

1d12	Whimsical Given Name	Whimsical Surname
1	Cricket	Borogove
2	Daisy	Goldjoy
3	Dimble	Hoddypeak
4	Ellywick	Huddle
5	Erky	Jollywind
6	Fiddlestyx	Oneshoe
7	Fonkin	Scramblewise
8	Golly	Sunnyhill
9	Mimsy	Tallgrass
10	Pumpkin	Timbers
11	Quarrel	Underbough
12	Sybilwick	Wimbly

Personality

With the NPC's alignment and ability scores as a starting point, use the guidelines in the *Player's Handbook* to pick a few words that describe the NPC's personality. You can choose or randomly determine one personality trait associated with each element of the NPC's alignment, or with the NPC's highest and lowest ability scores, and combine them to inspire a persona.

For example, if you find the adventurers unexpectedly arguing with a Lawful Neutral guard, you might create a cooperative but laconic guard who is happy to help the adventurers but speaks curtly, hoping to end the conversation as quickly as possible. Or, looking at the **Imp** stat block in the *Player's Handbook* and noting its highest ability (Dexterity) and its lowest (Strength), you might decide that the little devil is fidgety and indirect, constantly on the move and talking in circles to get to its point.

Appearance

Briefly describe the NPC's most distinctive physical features. You can start with the basics—skin, hair, and eye colors, as well as the NPC's species. The NPC Appearance table can also help you identify one or two things that stand out about the character's appearance.

NPC Appearance

1d12	Feature
1	Distinctive jewelry
2	Flamboyant, outlandish, formal, or ragged clothes
3	Uses an elegant mobility device (wheelchair, brace, or cane)
4	Pronounced scar
5	Unusual eye color (or two different colors)
6	Tattoos or piercings
7	Birthmark
8	Unusual hair color
9	Bald, or braided beard or hair
10	Distinctive nose (large, bulbous, angular, small)
11	Distinctive posture (stooped or rigid)
12	Exceptionally beautiful or ugly

Secret

Describe a secret the NPC is trying to hide or protect. The NPC Secrets table provides several ideas.



NPC TRACKER

NPC NAME: _____

STAT BLOCK: _____ MM PAGE: _____

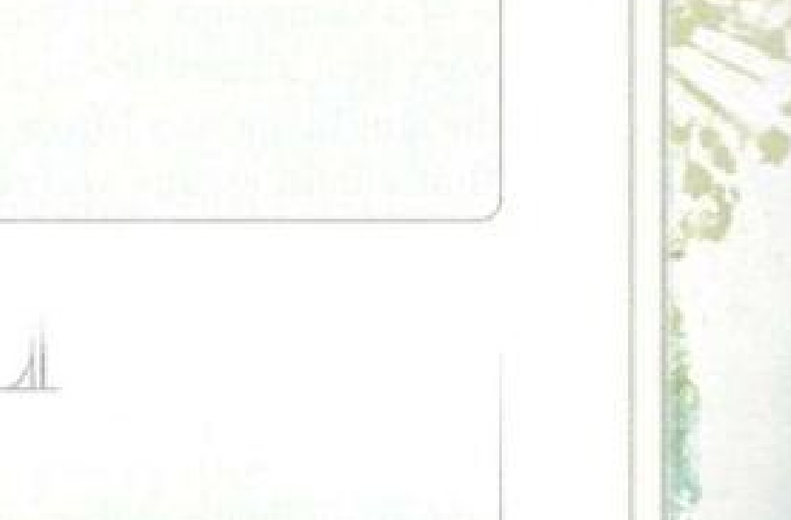
STAT BLOCK ALTERATIONS

ALIGNMENT

PERSONALITY

APPEARANCE

SECRET



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NPC Secrets

1d10	Secret
1	The NPC is in disguise, concealing their identity or some aspect of their appearance.
2	The NPC is currently planning, executing, or covering up a crime.
3	The NPC (or their family) has been threatened with harm unless the NPC does something.
4	The NPC is under a magical compulsion (perhaps a *Geas* spell or some kind of curse) to behave in a certain way.
5	The NPC is seriously ill or in terrible pain.
6	The NPC feels responsible for someone's death or ill fortune.
7	The NPC is on the brink of financial ruin.
8	The NPC is desperately lonely or harboring an unrequited passion.
9	The NPC nurses a powerful ambition.
10	The NPC is deeply dissatisfied or unhappy.

Recurring NPCs

NPCs who keep showing up over the course of a campaign build the sense that the world of the game is a living, breathing place. Whether these NPCs are allies, patrons, friends, or villains, they can deepen players' investment in the world.

You can use different stat blocks in the *Monster Manual*, perhaps with some tweaks, to reflect the same NPC at different times as they grow over the course of a campaign. For example, characters on their very first adventure might face a villain who uses the stat block of a **Mage Apprentice**, only to have that villain escape and return many adventures later to haunt them as a **Mage**. Still later, the same villain might reappear as an **Archmage**. Of course, the trick here is making sure that the villain survives from one adventure to the next, or at least coming up with a plausible way for the villain to return from death. After all, death is rarely the final word for adventurers, so it needn't be for their opponents.

Don't Go Overboard

Developing nonplayer characters can be fun. That said, use your time wisely. Beware of writing three pages of backstory for an NPC whose interactions with the adventurers will be over in three minutes. The advice in this section is meant to help you create an interesting character quickly while providing just enough detail.

NPCs as Party Members

NPCs might join the adventuring party because they want a share of the loot and are willing to accept an equal share of the risk, or they might follow the adventurers because of a bond of loyalty, gratitude, or love. You can delegate decisions about an NPC's actions to one of the players, especially in combat, but you can override the player's decisions to reflect the NPC's motivations.

When you choose a stat block from the *Monster Manual* for an NPC party member, make sure the NPC doesn't overshadow the player characters. Use a stat block whose Challenge Rating is no higher than half the characters' level. These NPCs don't amass Experience Points and don't become more powerful.

Here are some NPC archetypes that work well as supporting characters in an adventuring party:

Comic Relief. A comic relief NPC helps lighten the mood of an adventure or game session, perhaps with an occasional display of ineptness or a gift for puns.

Curmudgeon. A curmudgeon NPC is quick to complain humorously about the characters' terrible choices and bad planning. You can occasionally use this NPC to suggest legitimate courses of action or share insights.

Dutiful Assistant. A dutiful assistant NPC is good at carrying equipment and looking after the party's horses and other belongings. Such an NPC might be entirely devoted to their duty, or they might be using this easily overlooked position to pursue goals of their own.

Milquetoast Healer. Absent a healer of their own, the characters might love an NPC healer whose personality matters less than the healer's devotion to the party and ability to cast *Cure Wounds* or *Revivify* when needed.

Walking Textbook. A walking textbook NPC is knowledgeable about a particular field of expertise and can be a useful source of information, but they can't be relied on to make wise decisions or hold up their end in battle.

Wallflower Warrior. A wallflower warrior NPC is good at fading into the background, doesn't usually chat or engage unless approached, and eagerly avoids the spotlight. Their primary purpose is to give monsters another target to attack.

Even useful NPCs can slow down the game or overstay their welcome. Consider having NPC party members stick around for no more than a few game sessions or a single adventure before making their exit. NPCs can benefit from time away from the characters now and then.



As a member of another group of heroes, Niko first joined Sheila, Diana, Eric, and Presto as an NPC healer.

Loyalty

Loyalty is an optional rule you can use to determine how far an NPC party member will go to protect or assist the characters (even those the NPC doesn't particularly like). An NPC party member who is abused or ignored is likely to abandon or betray the party, whereas an NPC who owes a life debt to the characters or shares their goals might fight to the death for them. You can simply decide on an NPC's loyalty, or you can track a Loyalty Score using the following rules.

Loyalty Score. An NPC's loyalty is measured on a numerical scale from 0 to 20. The NPC's maximum Loyalty Score is equal to the highest Charisma score among all adventurers in the party, and its starting Loyalty Score is half that number. If the highest Charisma score changes—perhaps a character dies or leaves the group—adjust the NPC's Loyalty Score accordingly.

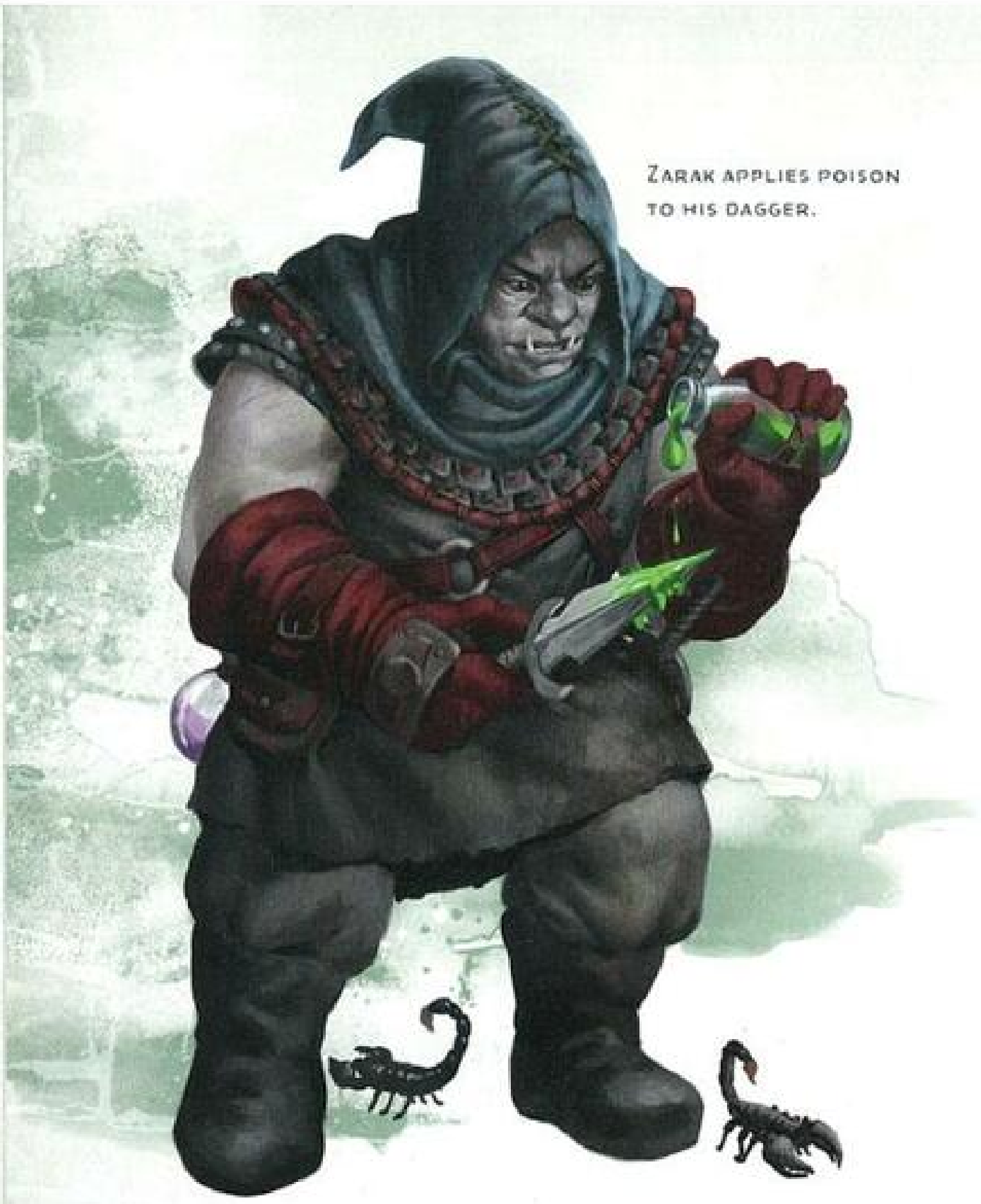
Tracking Loyalty. Keep track of an NPC's Loyalty Score in secret so that the players won't know for sure whether an NPC party member is loyal or disloyal.

An NPC's Loyalty Score increases by 1d4 if other party members help the NPC achieve a personal goal. Likewise, an NPC's Loyalty Score increases by 1d4 if the NPC is treated particularly well (for example, given a magic weapon as a gift) or rescued by another party member. An NPC's Loyalty Score can never be raised above its maximum.

When other party members act in a manner that runs counter to the NPC's alignment or personality, reduce the NPC's Loyalty Score by 1d4. Reduce the NPC's Loyalty Score by 2d4 if the NPC is abused, misled, or endangered by other party members for purely selfish reasons. A Loyalty Score can never drop below 0.

Meaning of Loyalty. An NPC with a Loyalty Score of 10 or higher risks anything to help fellow party members. An NPC whose Loyalty Score is between 1 and 10 is tenuously faithful to the party. An NPC whose Loyalty Score drops to 0 no longer acts in the party's best interests. The disloyal NPC either leaves the party (attacking characters who attempt to intervene) or works in secret to bring about the party's downfall.

Crew Loyalty and Mutiny. If the characters own or operate a sailing ship or similar vessel, you can use these rules to track the loyalty of individual crew members or the ship's crew as a whole. If at least half the crew's Loyalty Scores drop to 0 during a voyage, the crew turns Hostile and stages a mutiny. If the ship is berthed, disloyal crew members leave the ship and never return.



Zarak applies poison to his dagger.

Poison

Given their insidious and deadly nature, poisons are a favorite tool among assassins and evil creatures.

Poisons come in the following four types:

Contact. Contact poison can be smeared on an object and remains potent until it is touched or washed off. A creature that touches contact poison with exposed skin suffers its effects.

Ingested. A creature must swallow an entire dose of ingested poison to suffer its effects. The dose can be delivered in food or a liquid. You may decide that a partial dose has a reduced effect, such as allowing Advantage on the saving throw or dealing only half as much damage on a failed save.

Inhaled. Poisonous powders and gases take effect when inhaled. Blowing the powder or releasing the gas subjects creatures in a 5-foot Cube to its effect. The resulting cloud dissipates immediately afterward. Holding one's breath is ineffective against inhaled poisons, as they affect nasal membranes, tear ducts, and other parts of the body.

Injury. Injury poison can be applied as a Bonus Action to a weapon, a piece of ammunition, or similar object. The poison remains potent until delivered through a wound or washed off. A creature that takes Piercing or Slashing damage from an object coated with the poison is exposed to its effects.

Purchasing Poison

In some settings, laws prohibit the possession and use of poison, but an illicit dealer or unscrupulous apothecary might keep a hidden stash. Characters with criminal contacts might be able to acquire poison easily. Other characters might have to make extensive inquiries and pay bribes before they acquire the poison they seek.

Harvesting Poison

A character can attempt to harvest poison from a venomous creature that is dead or has the Incapacitated condition. The effort takes 1d6 minutes, after which the character makes a DC 20 Intelligence (Nature) check using a Poisoner's Kit. On a successful check, the character harvests enough poison for a single dose, and no additional poison can be harvested from that creature. On a failed check, the character is unable to extract any poison. If the character fails the check by 5 or more, the character is subjected to the creature's poison.

Sample Poisons

Example poisons are detailed here in alphabetical order. Each poison's description includes the suggested price for a single dose of the poison, its type (contact, ingested, inhaled, or injury), and a description of the poison's debilitating effects.

Assassin's Blood (150 GP)

Ingested Poison

A creature subjected to Assassin's Blood makes a DC 10 Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the creature takes 6 (1d12) Poison damage and has the Poisoned condition for 24 hours. On a successful save, the creature takes half as much damage only.

Burnt Othur Fumes (500 GP)

Inhaled Poison

A creature subjected to Burnt Othur Fumes must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or take 10 (3d6) Poison damage, and it must repeat the save at the start of each of its turns. On each successive failed save, the creature takes 3 (1d6) Poison damage. After three successful saves, the poison ends.

Carrion Crawler Mucus (200 GP)

Contact Poison

A creature subjected to Carrion Crawler Mucus must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw

or have the Poisoned condition for 1 minute. The creature also has the Paralyzed condition while Poisoned in this way. The creature repeats the save at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on itself on a success.

Essence of Ether (300 GP)

Inhaled Poison

A creature subjected to Essence of Ether must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or have the Poisoned condition for 8 hours. The creature also has the Unconscious condition while Poisoned in this way. The creature wakes up if it takes damage or if another creature takes an action to shake it awake.

Lolth's Sting (200 GP)

Injury Poison

A creature subjected to Lolth's Sting must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or have the Poisoned condition for 1 hour. If the creature fails the save by 5 or more, the creature also has the Unconscious condition while Poisoned in this way. The creature wakes up if it takes damage or if another creature takes an action to shake it awake.

Malice (250 GP)

Inhaled Poison

A creature subjected to Malice must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or have the Poisoned condition for 1 hour. The creature also has the Blinded condition while Poisoned in this way.

Midnight Tears (1,500 GP)

Ingested Poison

A creature that ingests Midnight Tears suffers no effect until the stroke of midnight. Any effect that ends the Poisoned condition neutralizes this poison. If the poison hasn't been neutralized before midnight, the creature makes a DC 17 Constitution saving throw, taking 31 (9d6) Poison damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Oil of Taggit (400 GP)

Contact Poison

A creature subjected to Oil of Taggit must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or have the Poisoned condition for 24 hours. The creature also has the Unconscious condition while Poisoned in this way. It wakes up if it takes damage.

Pale Tincture (250 GP)

Ingested Poison

A creature subjected to Pale Tincture must succeed on a DC 16 Constitution saving throw or take 3 (1d6) Poison damage and have the Poisoned condition. The Poisoned creature repeats the save every 24 hours, taking 3 (1d6) Poison damage on a failed save. The damage the poison deals can't be healed by any means while the creature remains Poisoned. After seven successful saves against the poison, the creature is no longer Poisoned.

Purple Worm Poison (2,000 GP)

Injury Poison

A creature subjected to Purple Worm Poison makes a DC 21 Constitution saving throw, taking 35 (10d6) Poison damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Serpent Venom (200 GP)

Injury Poison

A creature subjected to Serpent Venom must succeed on a DC 11 Constitution saving throw, taking 10 (3d6) Poison damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Torpor (600 GP)

Ingested Poison

A creature subjected to Torpor poison must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or have the Poisoned condition for 4d6 hours. The creature's Speed is halved while the creature is Poisoned in this way.

Truth Serum (150 GP)

Ingested Poison

A creature subjected to Truth Serum must succeed on a DC 11 Constitution saving throw or have the Poisoned condition for 1 hour. The Poisoned creature can't knowingly communicate a lie.

Wyvern Poison (1,200 GP)

Injury Poison

A creature subjected to Wyvern Poison makes a DC 14 Constitution saving throw, taking 24 (7d6) Poison damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Renown

Renown is an optional rule you can use to track characters' standing, individually or as a party, within a particular group, such as a faction, an organization, or a community.

A character's or party's Renown Score starts at 0, then increases as characters earn favor and reputation with respect to the group. You can tie benefits to a character's renown, including ranks, titles, and access to resources.

Players track renown separately for each group their characters are associated with. For example, an adventurer might have a Renown Score of 5 with one faction and a Renown Score of 20 with another, based on the character's interaction with each group.

You can use renown over the course of an entire campaign or within a single adventure. At a campaign scale, you might set up factions or guilds that characters can join, individually or as a group, and the characters pursue ranks and rewards by gaining Renown within their organizations. At an adventure level, you might decide that the characters as a group need to earn a Renown Score of 5+ with the council before the council trusts the characters enough to share resources with them.

Gaining Renown

At your discretion, a character or party can increase their renown in the following ways:

Completing Missions. Advancing a group's interests increases a character's Renown Score within that group by 1. Completing a mission specifically assigned by that group or that directly benefits the group increases the character's Renown Score by 2. Hugely significant quests might grant Renown Score increases of 3 or 4 at once.

Group Involvement. Once a character has established a Renown Score of 1+ with a group, the character can gain renown by spending time between adventures undertaking minor tasks for the group and socializing with its members. After doing so for a number of days equal to 10 times the character's current Renown Score, the character's Renown Score increases by 1.

Benefits of Renown

Use these guidelines when determining the benefits of increasing renown.

Recognition

A character who has a Renown Score of 3+ with a group is a respected member of that group. Other members of the group are Friendly toward the character by default and provide the character with lodging and food in dire circumstances.

Rank

Some groups have hierarchies that characters can ascend as they improve their Renown Scores. Other groups have positions of honor that characters can apply for if their Renown Score is high enough. Characters can earn promotions as their Renown Scores increase. You can establish certain Renown Score thresholds as prerequisites (though not necessarily the only prerequisites) for advancing in rank. You can set these thresholds however you like, creating ranks and titles for the groups in your campaign.

Perks

Earning renown within a group might come with certain benefits. A character with a Renown Score of 3+ might gain access to a reliable contact, a safe house, or a discount on adventuring gear. With a Renown Score of 10+, a character might gain access to Potions and Scrolls, the ability to call in a favor, or backup on dangerous missions. A character whose Renown Score rises to 50 might be able to call on a small army, acquire a Rare magic item, gain access to a helpful spellcaster, or assign special missions to members of lower status.

Losing Renown

Disagreements with members of a group aren't enough to cause a loss of renown within that group. However, serious offenses committed against the group or its members can result in a loss of renown and rank within the organization. The extent of the loss depends on the infraction and is left to your discretion. A character's Renown Score with a group can never drop below 0.

Level-Based Renown

If you want to use the benefits of renown without tracking Renown Scores, you can use a character's level as a shorthand for the character's Renown Score with a group, assuming the character has worked with or for that group for most of the character's career. The Level-Based Renown table shows equivalencies between Renown Score and character level.

Level-Based Renown

Renown Score	Character Level
1	1
3	3
10	5
25	11
50	17



Settlements

Your campaign world is likely to include settlements that characters can visit. The characters might even adopt one of these settlements as a home base, in or near which they can build their Bastions when they are of high enough level to do so (see chapter 8).

The Settlements by Size table provides population ranges for villages, towns, and cities as well as the value of the most expensive item the settlement is likely to have for sale. Adjust these numbers as you wish to account for special circumstances. For example, a *Potion of Healing* (which costs 50 GP) is too expensive an item to purchase in most villages, but a village that happens to have an alchemist, an herbalist, or a potion brewer might have one or more such potions for sale.

Settlements by Size

Settlement	Population Range	Max. GP Value
Village	Up to 500	20 GP
Town	501–5,000	2,000 GP
City	5,001 and higher	200,000 GP

Settlement Tables and Tracker

The following tables allow you to flesh out details about a settlement. You can use the accompanying Settlement Tracker to record important information about a village, town, or city in your campaign.

Defining Traits

1d20	Trait
1–2	Fortified outer wall
3–4	Lots of gardens, parks, and greenery
5–6	Lots of mud, filth, and litter
7–8	Sprawling cemetery
9–10	Lingering fog
11–12	Noise and smoke from smithies and forges
13	Canals and bridges
14	Cliffs on one or more sides
15–16	Clean streets and well-maintained buildings
17–18	Ancient ruins within the settlement
19–20	Impressive structure (such as a keep, temple, circle of standing stones, or ziggurat)

Do I Need a Settlement Map?

A settlement doesn't always require a map. Simply describing the settlement to your players is usually sufficient. But if it's important for the players to know where certain buildings or other locations are in the settlement, having a map is helpful.

For an example of a settlement map, see the Crossroads Village map in appendix B.

Claims to Fame

1d20	Claim to Fame	1d20	Claim to Fame
1	Delicious food	11	Piety
2	Rude people	12	Gambling
3	Friendly folk	13	Godlessness
4	Artists or writers	14	Education
5	Great hero/savior	15	Wines
6	Flowers	16	High fashion
7	Seasonal festival	17	Political intrigue
8	Hauntings	18	Powerful guilds
9	Spellcasters	19	Patriotism
10	Decadence	20	Ancient ruins

Current Calamities

1d12	Calamity
1	Monsters infest the settlement.
2	A key figure died; murder is suspected.
3	War brews between rival guilds or gangs.
4	A plague or famine sparks riots.
5	Monsters attack anyone who approaches or leaves the settlement.
6	Trade disputes cause economic hardship.
7	A natural disaster threatens the settlement.
8	A prophecy of doom has residents on edge.
9	Locals are being drafted to fight in a war.
10	Political or religious strife threatens violence.
11	The settlement is under siege.
12	Scandal threatens powerful local families.

Local Leaders

1d12	Leader
1	Respected, fair, and just leader or council
2	Feared tyrant
3	Coward manipulated by others
4	Illegitimate leader causing civil unrest
5	Powerful monster
6	Mysterious, anonymous conspirators
7	Contested leadership (with open fighting)
8	Acrimonious council unable to make decisions
9	Doltish lout
10	Dying leader (with disputed succession)
11	Iron-willed and respected leader or council
12	Religious leader or council

Tavern Names*

1d20	First Part	Second Part
1	The Golden	Lyre
2	The Silver	Dolphin
3	The Beardless	Dwarf
4	The Laughing	Pegasus
5	The Dancing	Hut
6	The Gilded	Rose
7	The Stumbling	Stag
8	The Wolf and	Duck
9	The Fallen	Lamb
10	The Leering	Demon
11	The Drunken	Goat
12	The Wine and	Spirit
13	The Roaring	Horde
14	The Frowning	Jester
15	The Barrel and	Bucket
16	The Thirsty	Crow
17	The Wandering	Satyr
18	The Barking	Dog
19	The Happy	Spider
20	The Witch and	Dragon

*Roll a separate d20 for each part of the tavern's name.

Random Shops

1d20	Type	1d20	Type
1	Pawnshop	11	Smithy
2	Apothecary	12	Carpenter
3	Grocer	13	Weaver
4	Delicatessen	14	Jeweler
5	Potter	15	Baker
6	Undertaker	16	Mapmaker
7	Bookstore	17	Tailor
8	Moneylender	18	Ropemaker
9	Armorer	19	Mason
10	Chandler	20	Scribe



SETTLEMENT TRACKER



SETTLEMENT NAME: _____

○ VILLAGE (POP. UP TO 500) ○ TOWN (POP. 501–5,000) ○ CITY (POP. 5,001+)

DEFINING TRAIT

CLAIM TO FAME

CURRENT CALAMITY

LOCAL LEADER

NOTEWORTHY PEOPLE

_____

_____

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_____

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_____

_____

NOTEWORTHY PLACES

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GP VALUE OF THE MOST EXPENSIVE ITEM FOR SALE: _____

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Siege Equipment

Siege equipment includes objects designed to assail castles and other walled fortifications. Most siege weapons require creatures to move them, as well as to load, aim, and fire them.

Ballista

Large Object

Armor Class: 15 **Hit Points:** 50

Ballista Bolt (Requires Load and Aim). *Ranged Attack Roll:* +6, range 120/480 ft. *Hit:* 16 (3d10) Piercing damage.

A Ballista is a massive crossbow that fires heavy bolts. Loading a Ballista requires the Utilize action, and aiming it requires another Utilize action. Then a crew member can take the Ballista Bolt action.

Cannon

Large Object

Armor Class: 19 **Hit Points:** 75

Cannonball (Requires Load and Aim). *Ranged Attack Roll:* +6, range 600/2,400 ft. *Hit:* 44 (8d10) Bludgeoning damage.

A Cannon uses gunpowder or arcane power to propel heavy iron balls at destructive speeds. A Cannon is usually attached to a wooden frame with wheels. Loading a Cannon requires the Utilize action, and aiming it requires another Utilize action. Then a crew member can take the Cannonball action.

Flamethrower Coach

Large Object

Armor Class: 19 **Hit Points:** 100

Flamethrower. *Dexterity Saving Throw:* DC 15, each creature in a 60-foot-long, 5-foot-wide Line. *Failure:* 14 (4d6) Fire damage, and the creature starts burning. *Success:* Half damage only.

Powered by magic, this iron coach has a flamethrower turret mounted atop it.

The coach can accommodate up to two Medium creatures. An iron hatch in the vehicle's underbelly grants access. Narrow slits in the front, sides, and back of the coach allow its occupants to see outside. A creature in the coach has Three-Quarters Cover against attacks and other effects that originate outside it.

The coach is designed for a crew of two: a driver and a gunner. The driver can take the Utilize action to move and turn the coach, which has a Speed of 30 feet, using levers and pedals inside. The gunner can use the Flamethrower action to aim and fire it.



Keg Launcher

Keg Launcher

Large Object

Armor Class: 15 **Hit Points:** 30

Toxic Keg (Requires Load and Aim). *Constitution Saving Throw:* DC 15, each creature in a 20-foot-radius Sphere centered on a point 30 to 300 feet from the launcher. *Failure:* 14 (4d6) Poison damage. *Success:* Half damage.

A back-mounted, wooden catapult flings small kegs of toxic gas. Loading a Keg Launcher requires the Utilize action, and aiming it requires another Utilize action. Then a crew member can take the Toxic Keg action.

Lightning Cannon

Medium Object

Armor Class: 19 **Hit Points:** 30

Lightning Ball (Requires Aim). *Ranged Attack Roll:* +6, range 300/1,200 ft. *Hit:* 22 (4d10) Lightning damage.

A Lightning Cannon is a small, bronze cannon inlaid with arcane runes and mounted on a heavy tripod device. It launches balls of crackling electricity.

Aiming a Lightning Cannon requires the Utilize action, then a crew member can take the Lightning Ball action.

Mangonel

Large Object

Armor Class: 15 **Hit Points:** 100

Mangonel Stone (Requires Load and Aim). *Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 200/800 ft. (can't hit targets within 60 feet of itself). *Hit:* 27 (5d10) Bludgeoning damage.

A Mangonel is a catapult that hurls heavy projectiles in a high arc, so it can hit targets behind walls. Loading a Mangonel requires two Utilize actions, and aiming it requires two more Utilize actions. Then a crew member can take the Mangonel Stone action.

Ram

Large Object

Armor Class: 15 **Hit Points:** 100

Ram (Requires Position). *Melee Attack Roll:* +8, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 16 (3d10) Bludgeoning damage.

A Ram consists of a movable gallery equipped with a heavy log suspended from two roof beams by chains. The log is shod in iron and used to batter through doors and barricades. Positioning a Ram requires three Utilize actions. Then a crew member can use the Ram action.

The gallery roof gives the operators Total Cover against attacks and other effects from above.

Siege Tower

Gargantuan Object

Armor Class: 15 **Hit Points:** 200

A Siege Tower is a mobile wooden structure with a beam frame and slats in its walls. Large wooden wheels or rollers allow the tower to be pushed or pulled by soldiers or beasts of burden. Medium or smaller creatures can use the Siege Tower to reach the top of walls up to 40 feet high. A creature in the tower has Total Cover against attacks and other effects that originate outside it.

Suspended Cauldron

Large Object

Armor Class: 19 **Hit Points:** 20

Spill (Requires a Full Cauldron). *Dexterity Saving Throw:* DC 15, each creature in a 10-foot square directly below the cauldron. *Failure:* 10 (3d6) Fire damage. *Success:* Half damage.

An iron pot is suspended so that it can be tipped easily, spilling its contents. Once emptied, a cauldron must be refilled before it can be used again. Filling the cauldron requires three Utilize actions. Then a crew member can take the Spill action.

Cauldrons are typically filled with boiling oil but can be filled with other substances, such as acid or green slime (see "Hazards" in this chapter), with different effects.

Trebuchet

Huge Object

Armor Class: 15 **Hit Points:** 150

Trebuchet Stone (Requires Load and Aim). *Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 300/1,200 ft. (can't hit targets within 60 feet of itself). *Hit:* 44 (8d10) Bludgeoning damage.

A Trebuchet is a catapult that throws its payload in a high arc so it can hit targets behind walls. Loading a Trebuchet requires two Utilize actions, and aiming it requires two more Utilize actions. Then a crew member can take the Trebuchet Stone action.



Mangonel



A MAGICAL CREATURE LIKE A UNICORN MIGHT BESTOW A SUPERNATURAL GIFT.

Supernatural Gifts

A supernatural gift is a special reward granted by a being or force of great magical power. Supernatural gifts come in two forms:

Blessing. A Blessing is usually bestowed by a god or a godlike being.

Charm. A Charm is usually the work of a powerful spirit, a magical location, or a mythic creature.

Unlike a magic item, a supernatural gift isn't an object and doesn't require Attunement.

Blessings

A character might receive a Blessing from a deity for doing something truly momentous—an accomplishment that catches the attention of both gods and mortals. A Blessing is an appropriate reward for one of the following accomplishments:

- Restoring a god's most sacred shrine
- Foiling an apocalyptic plot by a god's enemies
- Helping a god's favored servant complete a quest

An adventurer might also receive a Blessing in advance of a perilous quest. For example, a Paladin could receive one before setting out on a quest to slay a terrifying lich that is responsible for a magical plague sweeping the land.

A character should receive a Blessing only if it is useful to that character, and some Blessings come with expectations on the part of the benefactor. A god might give a Blessing for a particular purpose, such as recovering a holy person's remains or toppling a tyrannical empire, and could revoke the Blessing if a character fails to pursue that purpose or acts counter to it.

A character retains the benefit of a Blessing forever or until it is taken away by the being who granted it.

There is no limit on the number of Blessings a character can receive, but it should be rare for a character to have more than one at a time. Moreover, a character can't benefit from multiple instances of a Blessing at the same time. For example, a character can't benefit from two instances of the *Blessing of Health* at once.

You can easily create more Blessings by mimicking the properties of a Wondrous Item.

Blessing of Health

Supernatural Gift (Blessing)

Your Constitution score increases by 2, up to a maximum of 22.

Blessing of Magic Resistance

Supernatural Gift (Blessing)

You have Advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Blessing of Protection

Supernatural Gift (Blessing)

You gain a +1 bonus to AC and saving throws.

Blessing of Understanding

Supernatural Gift (Blessing)

Your Wisdom score increases by 2, up to a maximum of 22.

Blessing of Valhalla

Supernatural Gift (Blessing)

This Blessing grants you the power to summon spirit warriors, as if you are blowing a silver *Horn of Valhalla*. Once you use this Blessing, you can't use it again until 7 days have passed.

Blessing of Weapon Enhancement

Supernatural Gift (Blessing)

One nonmagical weapon in your possession becomes a *+1 Weapon* while you wield it.

Blessing of Wound Closure

Supernatural Gift (Blessing)

This Blessing grants you the benefits of a *Periapt of Wound Closure*.

Charms

Charms can be received in many different ways. For example, a Wizard who finds an eldritch secret in a dead archmage's spellbook might be infused with the magic of a Charm, as might a character who solves a sphinx's riddle or drinks from a magical fountain. Mythic creatures sometimes grace their allies with Charms, and some explorers find themselves bearing a Charm after discovering a long-lost location drenched in primeval magic.

Some Charms can be used only once; others can be used a specific number of times before vanishing. If a Charm lets a character cast a spell, the character can do so without expending a spell slot or providing any spell components. Unless otherwise stated, the spell uses its normal casting time, range, and duration; if the spell requires Concentration, the character must concentrate.

A Charm can't be removed from a creature by anything short of divine intervention or a *Wish* spell. A character can't benefit from multiple instances of a Charm at the same time.

A typical Charm mimics the effects of a Potion or spell, so it is easy to create more Charms of your own.

Charm of Animal Conjuring

Supernatural Gift (Charm)

This Charm allows you to cast *Conjure Animals*. Once used three times, the Charm vanishes from you.

Charm of Darkvision

Supernatural Gift (Charm)

This Charm allows you to cast *Darkvision*. Once used three times, the Charm vanishes from you.

Charm of Feather Falling

Supernatural Gift (Charm)

This Charm grants you the benefits of a *Ring of Feather Falling*. These benefits last for 10 days, after which the Charm vanishes from you.

Charm of Heroism

Supernatural Gift (Charm)

This Charm allows you to give yourself the benefit of a *Potion of Heroism* as a Magic action. Once you do so, the Charm vanishes from you.

Charm of Restoration

Supernatural Gift (Charm)

This Charm has 3 charges. You can expend some of its charges to cast one of the following spells: *Greater Restoration* (2 charges) or *Lesser Restoration* (1 charge). Once all its charges have been expended, the Charm vanishes from you.

Charm of the Slayer

Supernatural Gift (Charm)

One weapon in your possession becomes a *Dragon Slayer* or *Giant Slayer* (DM's choice) for the next 9 days. The Charm then vanishes from you, and the weapon returns to normal.

Charm of Vitality

Supernatural Gift (Charm)

This Charm allows you to give yourself the benefit of a *Potion of Vitality* as a Magic action. Once you do so, the Charm vanishes from you.

Traps

Traps should be used sparingly, lest they lose their charm. A hidden pit can be a fun surprise, but too many traps in an adventure can lead players to become overly cautious, which slows down the game.

The best traps are fleeting distractions that skilled characters can overcome in a short amount of time or deadly puzzles that require quick thinking and teamwork to overcome. Traps that are undetectable and inescapable are rarely fun.

Parts of a Trap

The description of a trap includes the following parts after the trap's name:

Severity and Levels. A trap is designated as a nuisance or as deadly for characters of certain levels. A nuisance trap is unlikely to seriously harm characters of the indicated levels, whereas a deadly trap can grievously damage characters of the indicated levels.

Trigger. Traps are often set to go off when a creature enters an area or touches an object. Examples of triggers include stepping on a pressure plate, crossing a trip wire, turning a doorknob, or using the wrong key in a lock.

Duration. Some traps have durations expressed in rounds, minutes, or hours. Others specify that their effects last until the trap is destroyed or dispelled. If a trap's duration is instantaneous, its effect is resolved instantly. If a trap resets after activating, that fact is noted in this entry. A trap is otherwise inert after activation.

Use caution when introducing a trap to characters of a level lower than the trap's level range. A trap that is a nuisance at one level range could be deadly to characters of a lower level range.

Example Traps

Traps are presented in alphabetical order.

Collapsing Roof

Deadly Trap (Levels 1–4)

Trigger: A creature crosses a trip wire
Duration: Instantaneous

This trap uses a trip wire to collapse an unstable section of ceiling. The trip wire is 3 inches off the ground and stretches between two weak supports that topple when the trip wire is pulled.

The first creature that crosses the trip wire causes the supports to topple and the unstable section of ceiling to collapse. Each creature beneath the unstable section of ceiling must succeed on a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw, taking 11 (2d10) Bludgeoning damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one. Rubble from the collapse turns the trapped area into Difficult Terrain.

Detect and Disarm. As a Search action, a creature can examine the trapped area and make a DC 11 Wisdom (Perception) check, detecting the trip wire and the unstable section of ceiling on a successful check. Once detected, the trip wire can be easily cut or avoided (no ability check required).

At Higher Levels. You can scale the trap for higher levels by increasing the damage and the save DC, as shown in the following table.

Levels	Bludgeoning Damage	Save DC
5–10	22 (4d10)	15
11–16	55 (10d10)	17
17–20	99 (18d10)	19

Falling Net

Nuisance Trap (Levels 1–4)

Trigger: A creature crosses a trip wire
Duration: Instantaneous

A falling net trap uses a trip wire to release a weighted, 10-foot-square Net suspended from the ceiling. The trip wire is 3 inches off the ground and stretches between two columns or trees.

The first creature that crosses the trip wire causes the Net to fall on it. The target must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or have the Restrained condition until it escapes. The target succeeds automatically if it's Huge or larger. A creature can take an action to make a DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check, freeing itself or another creature within its reach from the Net on a successful check.

Detect and Disarm. As a Search action, a creature can examine the trapped area and make a DC 11 Wisdom (Perception) check, detecting the trip wire and the suspended Net on a successful check. Once detected, the trip wire can be easily cut or avoided (no ability check required).

Destroy the Net. Reducing the Net to 0 Hit Points frees any creature trapped in it (see the *Player's Handbook* for the Net's statistics).

Set the Trap. A creature that has Thieves' Tools and all the trap's components (including a Net) can try to set a falling net trap, doing so with a successful DC 13 Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check. Each attempt to set this trap takes 10 minutes.

At Higher Levels. You can scale the trap for higher levels by increasing the weight of the Net, which increases the save DC and the DC of the Strength (Athletics) check as follows: DC 12 at levels 5–10, DC 14 at levels 11–16, or DC 16 at levels 17–20.

Fire-Casting Statue

Deadly Trap (Levels 1–4)

Trigger: A creature moves onto a pressure plate
Duration: Instantaneous, and the trap resets at the start of the next turn

When a creature moves onto this trap's pressure plate for the first time on a turn or starts its turn there, a nearby statue exhales a 15-foot Cone of magical flame. The statue can look like anything, such as a dragon or a wizard. Each creature in the Cone must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw, taking 11 (2d10) Fire damage on a failed save or half as much damage on a successful one.

Detect and Disarm. A *Detect Magic* spell reveals an aura of Evocation magic around the statue. As a Search action, a creature within 5 feet of the statue can examine it and make a DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check, detecting a tiny glyph on the statue on a successful check. Once the glyph is found, a character can take a Study action to examine it and make a DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) check, ascertaining that the glyph means "fire" on a successful check. As an action, a character can use a sharp tool to deface the glyph, which disarms the trap.

As a Search action, a creature can examine the section of floor that forms the pressure plate and make a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check, detecting the pressure plate on a successful check. Wedging an Iron Spike or similar object under the pressure plate prevents the trap from triggering.

At Higher Levels. You can scale the trap for higher levels by increasing the damage and the area of effect, as shown in the following table.

Levels	Fire Damage	Area of Effect
5–10	22 (4d10)	30-foot Cone
11–16	55 (10d10)	60-foot Cone
17–20	99 (18d10)	120-foot Cone

Hidden Pit

Nuisance Trap (Levels 1–4)

Trigger: A creature moves onto the pit's lid
Duration: Instantaneous

This 10-foot-deep pit has a hinged lid constructed from material identical to the surrounding floor. When a creature moves onto the lid, it swings open like a trapdoor, causing the creature to fall into the pit. The lid remains open thereafter.

A creature that falls into the pit takes 3 (1d6) Bludgeoning damage from the fall.

Detect and Disarm. As a Study action, a creature can examine the section of floor that forms the pit's lid and make a DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check, detecting the pit on a successful check. Once the pit is detected, an Iron Spike or a similar object can be wedged between the pit's lid and the surrounding floor to prevent the lid from opening, thereby making it safe to cross. The cover can also be held shut using *Arcane Lock* or similar magic.

Escape. A creature needs a Climb Speed, climbing gear, or magic such as *Spider Climb* to scale the pit's smooth walls. You can make the pit easier to escape by adding cracks in the walls big enough to serve as handholds and footholds.

At Higher Levels. You can scale the trap for higher levels by increasing the pit's depth and damage, as shown in the following table.

Levels	Pit Depth	Bludgeoning Damage
5–10	30 feet	10 (3d6)
11–16	60 feet	21 (6d6)
17–20	120 feet	42 (12d6)

Poisoned Darts

Deadly Trap (Levels 1–4)

Trigger: A creature moves onto a pressure plate
Duration: Instantaneous, and the trap resets at the start of the next turn if it has activated fewer than three times

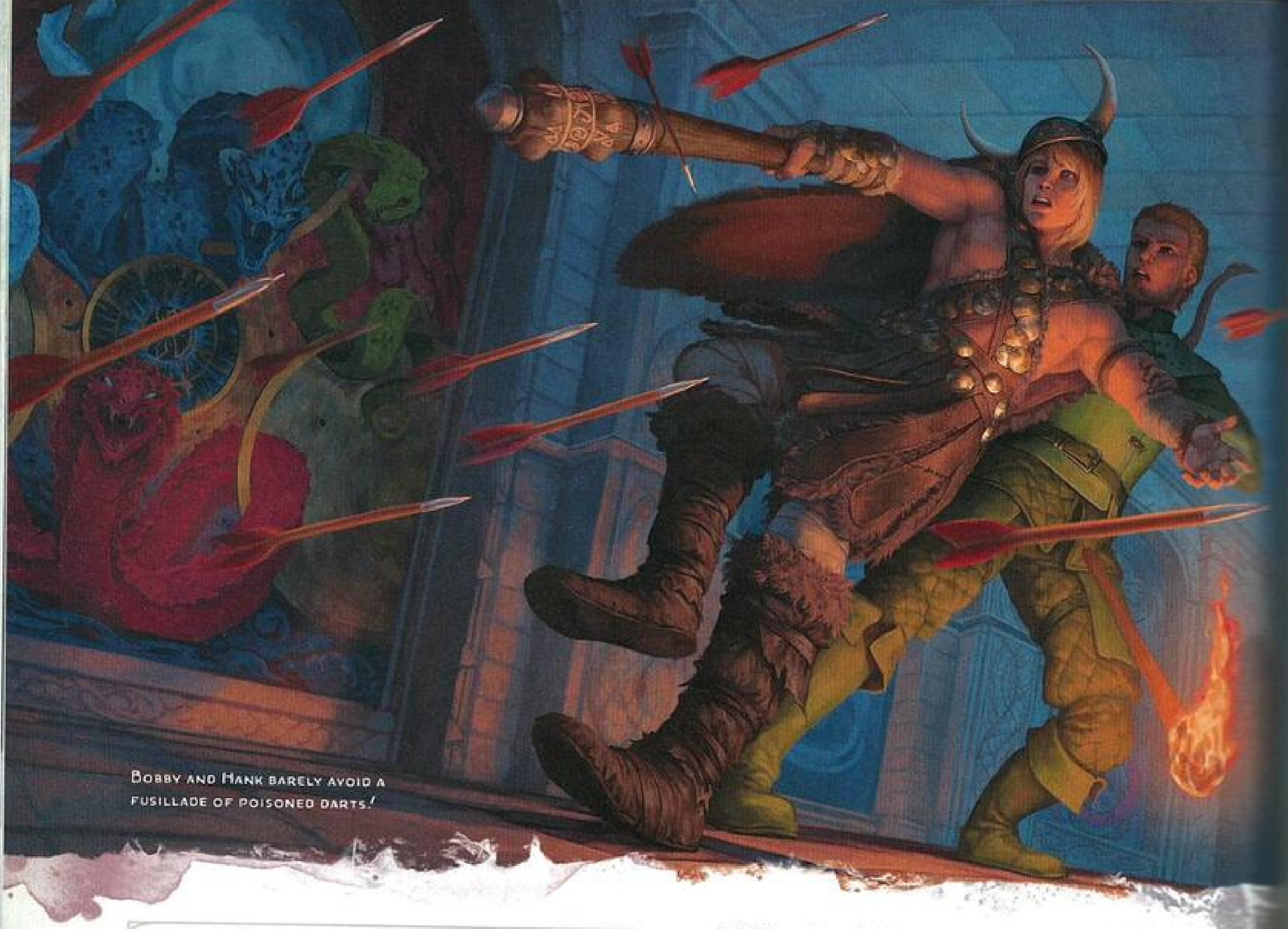
When a creature moves onto this trap's pressure plate for the first time on a turn, poisoned darts shoot from tubes embedded in the surrounding walls. The holes that house these tubes are obscured by dust and cobwebs or skillfully hidden amid bas-reliefs, murals, or frescoes.

Each creature in the darts' path must succeed on a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or be struck by 1d3 darts, taking 3 (1d6) Poison damage per dart.

Detect and Disarm. As a Search action, a creature can examine the walls and make a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check, detecting the holes on a successful check. Plugging all the holes with wax, cloth, or detritus prevents the darts from firing.

As a Search action, a creature can examine the section of floor that forms the pressure plate and make a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check, detecting the pressure plate on a successful check. Wedging an Iron Spike or a similar object under the pressure plate prevents the trap from triggering.

At Higher Levels. You can scale the trap for higher levels by increasing each dart's Poison damage as follows: 7 (2d6) at levels 5–10, 14 (4d6) at levels 11–16, or 24 (7d6) at levels 17–20.



Bobby and Hank barely avoid a fusillade of poisoned darts!

Poisoned Needle

Nuisance Trap (Levels 1–4)

Trigger: A creature opens the trap's lock improperly or fails to disarm the trap
Duration: Instantaneous

A poisoned needle is hidden in a lock. When a creature opens the lock with any object other than the proper key, the needle springs out and stabs the creature. The creature makes a DC 11 Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the creature takes 5 (1d10) Poison damage and has the Poisoned condition for 1 hour. On a successful save, the creature takes half as much damage only.

Avoid. The trap doesn't trigger if the lock is opened using a *Knock* spell or similar magic.

Detect and Disarm. As a Search action, a creature can examine the trapped lock and make a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check, detecting the needle on a successful check. Once the trap is detected, a character can take an action to try to disarm the trap, doing so with a successful DC 15 Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) check. On a failed check, the creature triggers the trap.

At Higher Levels. You can scale the trap for higher levels by increasing the damage and the save DC, as shown in the following table.

Levels	Poison Damage	Save DC
5–10	11 (2d10)	13
11–16	22 (4d10)	15
17–20	55 (10d10)	17

Rolling Stone

Deadly Trap (Levels 11–16) or Nuisance Trap (Levels 17–20)

Trigger: A creature moves onto a pressure plate
Duration: Until the stone stops rolling

When a creature moves onto a hidden pressure plate, a 5-foot-radius orb of solid stone is released from a secret compartment and begins to roll. The stone and all creatures nearby roll Initiative; the stone gets a +8 bonus on its Initiative roll.

On its turn, the stone moves 60 feet in one direction, changing course if redirected by an obstacle. The stone can move through creatures' spaces, and creatures can move through the stone's space,

treating it as Difficult Terrain. Whenever the stone enters a creature's space for the first time on a turn or a creature enters the stone's space while the stone is rolling, that creature must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or take 55 (10d10) Bludgeoning damage and have the Prone condition.

The stone stops when it hits a wall or similar barrier. It can't go around corners, but creative dungeon builders incorporate curving turns into nearby passages that allow the stone to keep moving.

Detect and Disarm. As a Study action, a creature can examine the section of floor that forms the pressure plate and make a DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check, deducing the pressure plate's function on a successful check. Wedging an Iron Spike or a similar object under the pressure plate prevents the trap from triggering.

Destroy the Stone. The stone is a Large object that has AC 17, HP 100, a Damage Threshold of 10, and Immunity to Poison and Psychic damage.

Slow the Stone. As an action, a creature can try to slow down the stone with a DC 20 Strength (Athletics) check. If the check is successful, the distance the stone moves on its turn is reduced by 15 feet. If that distance drops to 0, it stops moving and is no longer a threat.

Spiked Pit

Deadly Trap (Levels 1–4)

Trigger: A creature moves onto the pit's lid
Duration: Instantaneous

A 10-foot-deep pit has a hinged lid constructed from material identical to the surrounding floor. When a creature moves onto the lid, it swings open like a trapdoor, causing the creature to fall into the pit, which has sharpened wooden or metal spikes at the bottom. The lid remains open thereafter.

A creature that falls into the pit lands at the bottom and takes 3 (1d6) Bludgeoning damage from the fall plus 9 (2d8) Piercing damage from the spikes.

Detect and Disarm. As a Study action, a creature can examine the section of floor that forms the pit's lid and make a DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check, detecting the pit on a successful check. Once the hidden pit is detected, an Iron Spike or a similar object can be wedged between the pit's lid and the surrounding floor to prevent the lid from opening, thereby making it safe to cross. The cover can also be held shut using an *Arcane Lock* spell or similar magic.

Escape. A creature needs a Climb Speed, climbing gear, or magic such as a *Spider Climb* spell to scale the pit's smooth walls. You can make the pit easier to escape by adding cracks in the walls big enough to serve as handholds and footholds.

At Higher Levels. You can scale the trap for higher levels by increasing the pit's depth and damage, as shown in the following table.

Levels	Pit Depth	Damage
5–10	30 feet	10 (3d6) Bludgeoning plus 13 (3d8) Piercing
11–16	60 feet	21 (6d6) Bludgeoning plus 36 (8d8) Piercing
17–20	120 feet	42 (12d6) Bludgeoning plus 57 (13d8) Piercing

Building Your Own Traps

When designing your own traps, use the Building a Trap table to determine an appropriate total amount of damage for the trap to deal based on its level and severity. If the trap also applies a condition, consider reducing the damage.

If the trap requires an attack roll or allows a saving throw, use the appropriate columns on the table to determine the attack bonus or an appropriate save DC.

Building a Trap

	Nuisance Traps			Deadly Traps		
Levels	Attack Bonus	Save DC	Damage	Attack Bonus	Save DC	Damage
1–4	+4	10–12	5 (1d10)	+8	13–15	11 (2d10)
5–10	+4	12–14	11 (2d10)	+8	15–17	22 (4d10)
11–16	+4	14–16	22 (4d10)	+8	17–19	55 (10d10)
17–20	+4	16–18	55 (10d10)	+8	19–21	99 (18d10)